

KT MORRISON

Six Weeks in Winter

BOOK 1: SNOWSCAPE



SNOWSCAPE

SIX WEEKS IN WINTER

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About the Author

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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All characters are over the age of eighteen.

SNOWSCAPE

A **Six Weeks In Winter** book

35,000 words

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Written by KT Morrison

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Arrival

Evan's plane left on time at twelve-thirty, and she and John stood by the windows at the east side of the concourse and watched Flight 313 take off, ascend, shrink to a white sparkling dot in the huge azure sky then disappear. Her baby boy all grown up, a man now, on his own and flying to a foreign country.

She swore she wouldn't cry, and she didn't, at least not in front of Evan—he still had some of that teenage *Mom, you're embarrassing me!* residual angst, and she'd grown accustomed to hiding her emotions from him since he was eleven—but once her son was up in the air and getting more and more distant, she couldn't hold the tears back anymore.

"Uh-oh, here we go," John moaned, but he put his arm around her, and gave her a squeeze. That made it worse and now she sobbed. She buried her face into his flannel shirt, his big beard tickling her forehead, frayed Carhartt coat smelling of gas no matter how many times she washed it.

"Leave me alone," she laughed and sniffed. John put his other arm around her and told her to go on and get it out. She refrained, instead wiggling her nose around, fishing a tissue out of her pocket and giving her pump a honk, her back turned to John. He was checking his watch.

"What do you want to do now?" he said.

She shrugged, leaned her elbows on the railing that ran along the walkway and looked out at the sky again.

John said, "Good looking sky."

"Cold," she said. And cold was good. When it was clear and this cold the snow stayed away; and when the snow was away John was with her. And she needed him now. She stared up into the blue, imagining she could still see the wink of Evan's plane, but he was lost up there now, off to Italy for six weeks, where it would be warm and sunny and he would be happy and living his life to a fullness she'd always hoped.

She was a thirty-nine-year-old woman with a twenty-one-year-old son; a young and hapless mother at the age of eighteen that somehow found her

wits enough she had raised two good kids, both of them sharp and happy and attending university.

John rubbed her back now, squeezed her shoulder, and she stood upright again next to him. With his hand on her back, he guided her away from the window, leading her deeper down the concourse.



* * *

They were heading to the food court when John saw a familiar face coming their way through the crowds of travelers. He wasn't sure at first, the face seemingly larger, fatter, redder and devoid of the stubble he would expect. In fact, he'd convinced himself he was mistaken, and batted away the idea of approaching, but soon saw an unsure look on the approaching man's face probably similar to his own. Both of them began to smile as they grew close.

The man said, "Hey-ay, look at this guy!"

"Vic?"

They cut across foot traffic to come face-to-face, Janie close behind. He said, "Wow, hey, what's up, partner?"

"Same old, same old, you know..."

They shook hands, looking each other's faces over with halted smiles. John said, "How's Bentley Steel treating you?"

"I miss the old days."

"Hey, Jane, this is Vic, you remember him?"

Vic said, "We met once. Nice to see you again, Jane."

"I remember," she said, and shook Vic's hand.

John said, "He was the sales rep for Ang-Mar, you know, all the salt and sand, the stuff we have in the retail. Now he's out selling scrap steel."

Vic said, "How's that boy of yours—you got him out running the plows yet?"

"That's why we're here—sending him off to Italy."

"I wish I could send mine away to Italy," Vic said with a smile and winked; they shared a laugh.

Jane said, "He's at university, doing six weeks abroad."

“What—no? That’s incredible, he was always good with his hands around the shop, he doesn’t want to take over the family business?”

John said, “I wish—he wants nothing to do with it. I’m going to be working till I’m eighty.”

Vic laughed, said, “Well, good for him, at least there’s one smart Holcomb.”

John said, “There’s two. Remember my girl?”

“Marissa?”

“Hey, he remembers,” he said to Jane and thumbed at Vic. “She’s in college, too.”

“Wait—that little girl?” He held a hand out and level at his waist indicating the size their daughter used to be. “One was always in your office, liked to make paper airplanes, cute one with the braids all the time...?” He drew winding fingers to indicate imaginary braids running down the sides of his head; Jane had always done Marissa’s hair for her and he knew Janie missed those days when her little girl would sit at the kitchen table and get her hair braided and tell her about school; they’d just talked about it with Evan in the truck on their way here.

“First year at college. Wants to go to med school if you can believe it. You see why I’m going to die working.”

“Oh, whoa, a doctor, though? She’ll take care of you in your old age, huh?”

“One year at a time, I’m not going to close up just yet.”

“Jesus, though, eh? Where does the time go, John?”

“At least we’re still young, relatively speaking,” John said.

Vic laughed, said, “Good to get an early start on a family, now you can enjoy yourselves while your bodies are still holding up.”

John cocked his head and gave a wink, planted his two hands on the growing flannel belly that parted the open flaps of his jacket.

“You wear it well, big guy,” Vic said and John caught his eyes shifting to take in Janie, the guy’s salesman lizard brain calculating what he could get away with saying about John’s attractive wife. How she looked ten years younger than him, how she looked like she was in her twenties still and how John might pass as her father even though they were only one year apart. *Forty extra pounds and a beard add the years, and twelve hour work days did a number on me, m’man, but you don’t have to say a word about how pretty my Janie is.* Vic said nothing, seemed to smile knowingly, then

checked his watch. “Oh, shoot, speaking of time flying, I gotta run to make my connection. They got me going to New Hampshire these days.”

“More territory, more money,” John said and whapped Vic on the arm.

They shook hands with good strong grips and Vic said, “Just more problems, John.”

They laughed together again, said their farewells and wished Happy New Years and he and Janie watched Vic throw his bag over his shoulder and join the bustle of people on their way to the south end of the terminal.

“Good guy that one,” he said wistfully, but really reflecting on the nostalgia running into Vic had brought on. The last five years had seen a lot of big changes.



* * *

With an hour to kill between Evan’s departure and their boarding student’s arrival, John took her to the Anchor Grill, a sit-down restaurant outside the airport’s food court. They sat in a booth near the front, John ordered the Angus burger with cheese and bacon and she had a salad (but she did swipe a few of his fries). They split a pitcher of Labatt Blue Light but she only drank one glass. It was Sunday, and the game was on, Chargers and Rams, so John mostly viewed the TV over her shoulder while she looked out to the airport terminal and people-watched.

The closer it came to 1:30, the more anxious she got. She texted with her daughter to see how things were coming along; she texted with Roxy, her decade-long friend, neighbor, and confidante, at home with Marissa and overseeing arrangements at the homestead, to double check on Marissa’s report. When the first quarter of the football game ended, John checked his watch, bounced his eyebrows at her, put out a hand to be held. She did, taking his extra-large mitt in both of hers, running her thumbs over the hard, calloused shapes of his knuckles. He closed his fingers around her thumb and squeezed her. “It’s about that time,” he said.

With her hands in her pockets, she toddled along behind her husband as he paid the bill at the checkout and then they were out in the terminal again, walking side-by-side getting separated by oncoming travelers until they made it to the escalator to take them to the arrivals terminal on the lower

level. They gathered around United, standing at the back of an almost filled-up bank of theater seating, looking through the glass window as passengers from Rome disembarked.

The guest in their home over the next six weeks was a young man the same age as their son. A student as well, but not engineering like Evan; Maceo De Sanctis was an artist. His stay in their home was arranged through a program called Home-Exchange and Chesborough College just outside Rochester. They'd spoken to the young Italian man twice now on Skype and even spoke to his mother and father though the communication between them was difficult. Neither of his parents spoke English but Maceo was quite good and was coming to America to get better. It was Maceo's very home that Evan was departing for. While Maceo stayed in their home, the Home-Exchange program and University of Buffalo had their son in the De Sanctis's home just outside of Rome. They seemed like wonderful people and she hoped his parents thought the same of her and John.

"Hey, you see him yet?"

"No," she said, eyes scanning through the crowd. There were more than a few men in the right age group, and frankly they all kind of looked similar with dark eyes and dark hair. But no one stood out. She said, "I told you we should've brought a sign."

"I don't want to make a spectacle," he said, and she elbowed him.

Then coming through double sliding glass doors from TSA and into baggage claim was one more twenty-year-old man with dark hair and dark eyes. It was definitely Maceo. She hadn't expected him to be so tall—he'd been sitting with his family during their Skype sessions. He stood a head taller than anybody else in the crowd. She said, "Hey, John, that's him right there." She pointed.

"Tall bugger," John said.

They watched him collect two suitcases, a travel bag slung over his shoulder. He kept his head down as though he were shy, coming through politely, gesturing with his hands to get between people who were milling about without destination. He emerged, finally, through the second set of glass sliding doors and into the waiting theater. John went first, stepping forward saying, "Maceo?"

The young man lifted his chin (though he was tall enough he would still be looking down on John), then smiled wide, dipping to drop the bags on the floor. "Oh, hello, hey," he said, "Mr. and Mrs. Holcomb..."

“Hey, Maceo,” John said and put one of his big hands out to shake, but Maceo was already coming in, leaning forward, putting one arm around the small of John’s back and touching a cheek to either side of his face. John smirked, his hand still held out awkwardly but getting into it. “Hey,” he laughed, saying, “good to meet you, so glad you’re here,” and Janie was laughing, too, but at the funny Italian cadence John was speaking in.

“Mrs. Holcomb,” Maceo said now, turning her way, dipping at the knees again, and bending, doing the same to her as John, putting a hand at the small of her back. But instead of cheek-to-cheek, he kissed near her ear on both sides. They gave her the goosebumps and the giggle she’d stifled from John’s sudden Italian accent bubbled up. She said, “You’re really tall.”

“Yeah, hah,” he said, making a saluting gesture, and showing how his hand leveled from the top of his head over theirs, smiling the whole time and being good-natured.

John said, “You could’ve come on a basketball scholarship.”

Maceo nodded, keeping his smile on her, and she had the distinct sense that he didn’t know what that meant. She bumped John’s side with the back of her hand and said, “Leave him alone about being tall, I don’t think he knows what you mean.”

“Basketball, yes,” Maceo said, and gestured with a hand like he was shooting a three-pointer.

“See?” John said, chiding her.

“Whatever,” she said, “we’re so glad you’re with us. How was the flight?”

Maceo said, “Mostly I sleep, I watch a movie, it was good, Old Man with a Gun,” and John stooped to pick up one of the suitcases. Maceo brushed him away saying, “No, no, it’s okay,” but John insisted and now upped the ante, taking both the bags. Maceo thanked him earnestly.

She could tell he was nervous, there was a stiffness in his voice, and he was probably concerned about his English abilities now that he was in America. It was fine and dandy when you were the best English-speaking person in your neighborhood in Rome, but now he would be put to the test. But he was charming, and there was no way you could deny it: *really* good-looking. More so than he’d seemed on their computer screen. Definitely the kind of guy that would make you look twice, and it wasn’t just the height. He had a well-shaped face, masculine and sculpted, and a great head of hair; short on the sides but long and swooping up top; light in color which

she hadn't expected, his hair seemed dark on Skype, but she could see now it was chestnut with lighter sunburned streaks in it. He'd dressed for the Buffalo winter, though, like he was still prowling the streets of Europe; a black peacoat with the collar turned up, a burgundy scarf flowing around his sharp jawline.

She said, "Let's get out of the airport, Maceo, I hate this place and we've been here too long already."

John said, "We got people at home excited to meet you, you hungry?—there's going to be food," even though she'd asked him not to give away the surprise reception back at their place.

Maceo said, "Food, yes? I like food..."

John said, "Me too," and still holding the suitcases, squeezed his elbows against his sides to show off his stomach.

Maceo said, "American food? Hamburgers?"

"Shoot," John said, "I already had one..."

"We'll have all sorts of things," she told him, "a potluck."

They were weaving through the crowds again, heading towards shining daylight doors that would take them out to the parking. Maceo said, "What's potluck?"

"I don't know," she said, thinking about it. The last two weeks she'd spent perusing websites about Italian food and culture and even gone to the library to get CDs on learning Italian which she played in the kitchen while she was working. She said, "Buffet style, like, everyone brings something with them..."

"Si, si, thank you so much," he said.

"Now the real question," John said, accelerating and huffing and puffing, carrying a load in both hands, coming up beside Maceo, "you ready for a Buffalo winter?"

Cold Notes

John watched the kid's face when they went outside. *Welcome to the maelstrom, kiddo.* He didn't know what it was like in Italy, but he knew it wasn't like here. He ran plows up and down these streets, moving millions of tons of Buffalo snow so people could get to work every day. Eight feet of snow on the annual was what he moved, and there were day stretches where they might get half of that all at once. Sometimes it was twenty-degrees, that was pretty bad, but, hey, how do you feel about zero? Zero degrees wasn't out of the question, and neither was minus-ten. Had to be some art program at Chesborough to get the kid out of sunny Rome and into this mess.

He took great glee at the shocked look this young guy had on his face stepping out and having ice-air sizzle the surface of his handsome face. The kid recoiled, stepped back as if the cold had assaulted him. And it had.

"Hey, ha ha," he said and elbowed Maceo good-naturedly.

"Wow, how you say," Maceo said grimacing, pulling up his scarf to cover his cheeks looking like a bandit in a western movie, his how-you-say getting lost in the wool.

"Pretty cold, huh? How's the snow in Italy?"

Through the layers of wool scarf, Maceo said, "In Rome, it's no, but we have, you know, we go in the Alps," he said and drew a mountain peak with a fingertip in the air.

"Yeah, I bet it's cold up there. But nothing like Buffalo in January."

Janie had her scarf around her face now too, coming out of the sliding doors and putting her sunglasses on and pulling up her fur-trimmed hood. One of the good things about being a big guy like he was—a big burly guy with a beard—was a certain *limited* invulnerability to cold. He wouldn't survive in the elements overnight, but he didn't flinch walking in winter from a building to his truck. Jacket open, no scarf, no gloves, he strode proudly with Maceo's luggage, chest out, leading the way.

They'd parked in the preferred lot, open air, but right up front, and they passed through the garage which gave them a break from the wind. But by

the time they got to the truck he couldn't feel his hands, though he wouldn't tell anybody that. Janie took the keys out of his pocket and flicked the fob to unlock all four doors on the F250. Maceo was awed by the size of the truck. Jane opened the rear door, and he slid Maceo's luggage in. When Maceo moved to climb into the back, Janie stopped him, saying, "No, Maceo, you sit up front, I want you to take a good look around."

Maceo put both hands up and shook them, saying, "No, no, I sit in the back, the lady sits up front."

"The lady," John said, "look at you impressing my wife with your manners." Janie swatted at him, and he laughed, walking around to the other side saying, "You two sort it out, I know *I'm* driving."



* * *

Maceo insisted on her sitting up front and she didn't want to fight anymore because it was cold outside and he wasn't really dressed for northern winter. So now he was in the back bench, and the heat was blasting. It was a sunny and bright day, and they were leaving Buffalo and heading east on the 90 taking them out of the city. Maceo sat directly behind her, but she could see him in the side mirror as he watched out the window at the grim, frigid expanse of rural upstate. She said, "What do you think?"

"So much open space," he said.

"Isn't it beautiful?"

She could see him shake his head, not saying no, but almost as if to clear away webs of bewilderment. He said, "I can't believe I'm here. It really is beautiful, really something."

John laughed. "Buffalo—beautiful? Okay, then why's everyone want to go to Europe for the sightseeing?"

Maceo still watched out the window, studying the passing landscape, seeing something in its bleakness, maybe. She wondered what she would think of Buffalo if she'd never seen it before, came from somewhere completely different. "What are you thinking about?" she asked him.

"I want to paint it," he said.

“That’s a great idea,” she said, looking over to John. Now she leaned to her left side and turned around to look at Maceo sitting in the backseat. She said, “We cleared space at the house for you to work. I went out to Chesborough, and I picked up supplies. Easel and paints, and a bunch of other things they had for you. I brought them home and set them up in my studio.”

“Hey,” he said, leaning forward and holding the leather side of the passenger chair, “me and you, we paint together?”

“We can do that,” she said, her eyes fixed on the size of his hand where it curled around her seat. John was a big, burly guy with the strongest hands she knew, but Maceo’s hands were larger, the fingers longer; well-formed and well-groomed. John’s nails were chipped, torn, his fingerprints worn bald in places, dirt embedded in some of the remaining grooves even when washed with that orange stuff, and always rough as sandpaper. Maceo’s looked soft without being feminine at all.

John said, “Your folks excited to get Evan?”

“Oh, yes,” he said. “They have a big party later today. Six in the morning, but for Evan it night, so they make big meal, all my family there, my mother make everything—veal, clam, artichoke, oxtail, all kind of pasta, cake and all kind of cheese—I tell her she crazy, Evan, he want to go to sleep.”

John patted his stomach, said, “Wish I was going to Italy.”

She peeked around the edge of the chair at Maceo again, saying, “I hope you’re not ready for sleep...”



* * *

Their homestead was in Iroquois Falls, between Buffalo and Rochester, outside Batavia; a decidedly and unapologetically rural area but a good cheap spot to live and run two fields of trucks from, serving two developed areas: Buffalo and Rochester. Now they were heading north on Old Ogden Road; Maceo had undone his seatbelt so he could scoot forward to peer between the front seats and out the windshield. He said, “It’s all farms.” On either side of the vehicle were flat landscapes in white, dotted with the black shapes of barns and farmhouses.

Janie said, “You live in the city but do you ever get out to where it’s rural like this?”

“My uncle, he has a house in Campagna. Ah, *countryside*...?”

“We don’t farm, but we have a homestead,” Janie said. “Just a little plot where we can do what we want.”

“Privacy, in the land of privacy,” Maceo said, his fingers gesturing out the left and right windows indicating there was nothing around.

John said, “Heck, I don’t know about privacy, big brother and all,” but didn’t want to get into his conspiracy theories.

The open spaces narrowed and soon they were climbing into hilly country and the road grew closed with trees again. When he slowed and hit the indicator, Maceo was alert, scooting forward. John could smell some sort of faint aftershave.

He said, “Is this it? Are we here?”

“Just up ahead,” Janie said.

The winding, quarter-mile hill up to their homestead—‘High Countertop,’ Janie had named it back when they were in their mid-twenties—rose at almost twenty degrees and it was a good thing he owned a plow company because a lot of plows would turn down the job of their driveway.

“Oh, ho, big climb,” Maceo said, sitting back now as the Ford pushed its way up the hill, his plowed drive heavily sanded and salted, giving him lots of traction.

Soon they were leveling out in a clearing, a pressed-down thumbprint of cleared trees in a swath of bush. Up beside their two-story country farmhouse, was a short drive with Janie’s pickup, Evan and Marissa’s Yukon, a spot for him, his detached plow up on blocks waiting to get re-engaged. On the right, at the edge of what used to be pasture, there were almost a dozen cars parked. A spiral of lazy wood stove smoke puffed its way to the cold blue sky.

Maceo watched out the side window as John pulled the truck to a stop and put it in park. Janie watched too, wondering probably how things were going in there without her, worrying about food preparation and whether Marissa had a hold on the kitchen duties she’d been left with.

Their house was a little worn-in looking—but it was the quintessential home. The Holcomb Safe Place where the two of them had raised two kids, toughed out a hard knock life and forged a strong family. The kids had all raised livestock here, had their pets, learned the basics of independence,

hosted cookouts, camp-overs; Janie had even home-schooled the kids here until she'd been coaxed by Roxy to let them go public back when they were nine. It was the place where everything had happened—and now with the kids off to university and six-months into being empty-nesters it sure was nice to see their parking filled up and know the place was going to be hopping with a big group of their friends. Without the kids around, things had gone quiet. For nine years Janie rarely left this place, breast-feeding, quilting, canning, painting, reading, and chores, chores, chores; cooking meals, preparing lunches, making sure he had sandwiches and thermoses of coffee when he had to head out at three in the morning because the snow was coming down in sheets. It had been a wild time, scary, too. The homestead started out as a rental—they were just two dumb kids with a baby and one income but lots of dreams. Once Marissa was born, their second child, they'd borrowed money and purchased the property, gave it its homestead name. Then when he was twenty-eight, he bought the plow company he worked for, pushing down on the homestead with a huge mortgage. But he busted his ass like a mine worker to claw that money back and to make his business profitable. It was a constant struggle.

Maceo said, “So this is the home?—it’s so beautiful, so private...”

“That’s why we bought it,” Janie said, and her pretty hand curled over the tattered sleeve of his work coat.

He agreed: “That’s why we’re here, Maceo.”



* * *

There was a chance that Maceo could be overwhelmed by their planned reception, but walking up their path from the driveway she could see him smiling. Under the overhanging cover of the wraparound porch and through the corner windows of the dining room, she could see all the people congregated inside, standing with drinks in hand and gathered in small clutches talking to each other; probably around twenty guests in her house right now prepared to greet Maceo. None of them had spied their arrival—the driveway wasn’t seen from the living area—but now one particular face turned their way and shone bright with happiness. Their daughter, Marissa, with a glass of wine in her hand—she would have to talk to her about that

later—jolted, and was now bopping around in there and alerting everyone that they were home.

She led the way with Maceo behind her and John at the back carrying the kid's bags again. They were stomping their boots now, beating the snow off them on the porch's wooden decking, turning around the corner to get to the front door, everyone pressed up against the glass now just an arm's length away. She smiled and waved, and familiar faces in her home smiled and waved back

She paused at the front door as the inner one was opened by Marissa, and she turned to Maceo and said, "You ready for this?—just a few people..."

Maceo smiled and nodded, and she opened the storm door and held it for him. Marissa was right there to meet them, extending both hands in exuberant greeting. The crowd behind her shouted friendly hellos. Maceo put his out and held Marissa's right hand delicately with a thumb over the back of her knuckles. She watched her daughter's face transform momentarily then wrestle to control itself so she wouldn't betray her inner emotions—*yes, Marissa, your brother Evan's replacement is quite good looking*. Marissa had broken up with her high school boyfriend before her first year of college. He was a sweet kid, one that she'd been with since grade 11, and she didn't like to think of the things that may have happened right under her nose, but Marissa was a smart girl and if there was one thing that she had beaten into her it was to be careful. You could change your life very quick if you let things get out of hand...

She said, "This is, Maceo, Marissa... Maceo this is my daughter, Marissa..."

Marissa was pulling him in the house, saying, "Come on in, come in, get out of the cold, you're not used to it..."

She let her daughter take control, Marissa liked responsibility. She smiled at John, holding the door open for him so he could get in with the bags.

Now the three of them were jammed in the foyer, surrounded on three sides in the small space by their guests. The main floor of the farmhouse was probably just over a thousand square feet, most of it taken up in the center by a huge stone column with a fireplace on the dining room side and a cookstove on the kitchen side. The whole place was open concept, kitchen on the left, dining room on the right, the back area a pantry, mudroom, and

family room. Ten years ago John built her an addition that ran out behind the pantry and mudroom; an open space split between them with one side adorned with a big screen TV for John, the other half her studio space.

But right now there were more than twenty people all around the front door, blocking passage, everyone here to meet this Italian kid. Roxy was there with her daughter, Marissa's friend from high school, her son as well, quietly watching with a can of Coke and his bottle-thick glasses; John's business manager and good friend Mitch, Mitch's wife; Marissa had brought four of her girlfriends from college; Elizabeth, the elderly woman who ran her own little farm a mile down the road was there, her grown-up daughter; Dr. Bernard, her family doctor and homestead friend; and a whole host of people from town, some from the co-op, from school, from her painting group. Everyone shoved hands forward to greet Maceo. John set the bags down, clapped Maceo on the back, began doing the introductions and getting help from Marissa.

She slipped herself to the kitchen side, checking how things were coming along and getting her parka off before moving into the mudroom. She hung the parka on its hood and took off her snow boots. Roxy dipped her head in, saying, "You guys get in okay? How were the roads?"

"They were fine, everything's clear. Evan got away—God, I miss him already."

Roxy stepped in and rubbed her shoulder. "He's going to have a great time over there."

"I know he is, he's just so far away."

Roxy leaned her back against the wall and looked out at the greetings still going on by the front door. "You can baby this one while he's gone."

She said, "I don't baby Evan."

"Sure you don't," Roxy laughed.

She shrugged. "What am I going to do, Roxy? He *is* my baby..."

Welcome Party

Mitch and Jason Beck, John's second-in-command when it came to the plows, helped him take the bags up the stairs to Evan's bedroom where Maceo would be staying. "At least he made his bed," John said to them as they set the bags down in the center of the room. It was just a joke—Evan used to work at the depot and it was a constant source of fun for them all to rib him—no need to stop even if he wasn't around. Evan wasn't a messy kid, even when he was living at home, and it had been good to have him back over the holiday. His son was away at the University of Buffalo, in his third year of an engineering course and stayed in the dorms, but over Christmas he'd been here at home almost three weeks. He'd even spent time down at the depot, turning wrenches and driving a plow. But now the school year was back in swing and Evan was studying six weeks at the Università Roma Tre learning bridge making in Italy.

Mitch moved to the bedroom window, parted the curtain to look out at the sky. In the week between Christmas and New Year's, they'd run trucks twenty-four hours a day, but now the weather was held up and they had a short reprieve. It was a Sunday, but he had two guys back at the shop doing maintenance, and a crew out doing cleanups.

Mitch said, "Forecast says there's storms this week."

"Just when I was enjoying my time off," he said.

"What time off?" Jason said, clapping him on the back then sitting down on Evan's bed.

"Least I didn't work on Christmas day. That was nice this year."

Jason looked around the room, seeing Evan's football trophies, his shelves of young man stuff. "Kind of weird," he said, "it's like you're going to have a surrogate son."

Mitch said quietly, "I don't think that Maceo kid's going to be any good running the plows."

John laughed, said, "Kid's an artist."

Jason said, "Bring him down to the depot, we'll get him greasy. Any kid's an artist would do to learn a trade or two."

“Tell me about it,” John said.

Mitch said, “So what’s the kid doing?—art?”

“Uh-huh. Out to Rochester. Chesborough College. It’s all done through this Home Exchange program, they said there’s some hotshot instructor out there that teaches whatever Maceo’s into. Classical painting or something. But he’s really here—” now he motioned with a helicopter finger indicating his son’s room, “—to live life like an American kid.”

“In your home,” Jason said, staring at the floor. He’d expressed some doubts about the whole process—but it was just something that Janie did—bringing young people into their home was nothing new, especially when it would benefit their own kids, expose them to other cultures, allow them to have friends in foreign lands for when they were older and maybe looking to travel. There was a time three to ten years ago, back when the homestead had a lot more going on, she would open up the place to teenagers to come and stay. Mostly from Europe—some from Asia, though, even a few from Africa—they would come and stay for a week or two and do farm chores in trade for room and board. It was a lot of fun; Marissa and Evan loved it, and they made friends pretty much all over the world. That was how they ended up with the Home Exchange program and this kid Maceo coming. Three years ago they had this cute little fifteen-year-old girl come to stay with them, who helped Marissa and her mom in the vegetable gardens. She was from France, and still stayed in touch with Marissa, and wrote an email saying that her sister was doing Home Exchange and maybe Marissa would want to do that, come out and live in France and trade with some kid there. There was nothing in Marissa’s program that offered a foreign sabbatical, but there was an engineering course at the school in Rome and Marissa sold Evan on the idea. Home Exchange hooked them up with Maceo.

He looked at Jason, hearing the unsaid. “What’s the big deal?”

“Having a stranger in your house.”

He shrugged, said, “We do it all the time, kids from all over the world.”

“Yeah, but your guys’s kids are all grown up now, they’re out of the house. It’ll be Janie alone.”

Mitch said, “Maceo looks like an alright kid.”

John said, “Yeah, I don’t think I have to worry about him. He’s not some weirdo.”

“Good looking kid,” Jason said, still looking down at the floor. “Not really a kid, though.”

It was the first time it occurred to him: Janie would be home alone with this tall, handsome twenty-year-old. To get out of thinking about that, he stretched now and groaned, said, “Hey, who won the game?”



* * *

In the kitchen with Roxy, Elizabeth, Marianne from the co-op, Marissa and one of Marissa’s friends from UB, Amy (who was here for the first time but seemed at home in the kitchen), they all prepared to serve their early supper. The menu consisted of her carefully curated selection of American goods: Buffalo wings, because *of course*, with her special sauce of butter and extra cayenne the way John liked it; lobster sliders; Mac and cheese in mini baked dishes the size of muffins; crab cakes; homemade potato wedges done in the deep fryer. And she would be remiss to leave out the iconic apple pie—there were three baking right now in her Findlay wood cookstove, to be served with American cheddar. Roxy had insisted on baking a cake, and it was chilling in the pantry fridge; vanilla layers sandwiched over red frosting and an icing American flag across the top that she had done herself by hand.

Not that it was a competition, but she wondered how Maceo’s parents would fare in their reception of Evan compared to this American extravaganza. She could see Maceo standing a head taller than all the guys, John, and Mitch, and Jason, and some others from town, all of them with brown bottles of beer in their hand. Roxy’s son, Trevor, stood in the corner watching over top of his glasses while pretending to play on his Game Boy, spying the other clutches standing and talking, especially all the college girls around the dining room table, all of them in their cute little clothes—their flannels and denim because Mar told them they’d be roughing it out in the country. Elbows on the table, their faces were close together—it was obvious what they were talking about because every once in a while one of them would shoot a look over at Maceo and then they would talk again in close conspiracy.

Roxy said, “We’re just about set.”

Elizabeth said, “ETA in fifteen minutes, Janie,” as she put the crab cakes in the gas oven for a final browning.

But she could see Marissa now, coming up behind Maceo and gently holding the back of his arm, cupping his elbow. He looked to her, stooped down so she could whisper something in his ear. Then the two of them were heading toward the stairs to the second floor.

“Man my spot,” she said to Elizabeth who nodded and popped a carrot stick in her mouth. They had the radio on, and in their slippers they’d been slipping across the hardwood floors, dancing their booties while they cooked. She stopped her daughter and Maceo on the stairs, saying, “Dinner’s in about ten, you going to show Maceo his room now?”

Without a look or hint of guilt her daughter smiled and said, “Yeah, I was going to give him the second floor tour—he didn’t even get a chance to clean up since he got home.”

She gestured for them to go up the stairs ahead of her and followed behind. Their tight staircase was narrow and unfinished, not even a hand railing at this point, though John swore he would get to it soon. The second floor was cramped quarters. Her and John had the master bedroom with an en suite bathroom that looked over the front of the house and the valley beyond. Right hand, top of the stairs, was Marissa’s old bedroom (still hers, really, she’d even stayed over Christmas); on the left-hand side at the very top of the stairs was Evan’s room where Maceo would be staying. There was one small bathroom—sink, toilet, and bathtub with shower head—that butted the master suite that Evan and Marissa had shared (sometimes sharing, too, with kids visiting from overseas).

The small square space at the center and left corner of the second floor was *her* room. The place where she used to do *everything* back when the kids were little. It was her seamstress place, her study, she used to paint, too, when there was time; it was even the home school classroom where she taught the kids before they finally went public in grade 5. Now it looked like a thrift shop had opened up at a tailor’s. Center were green felt-topped tables, her refurbished Swiss sewing machines, and sewing machine parts; shelves lined the wall, stacked with yarn and rolls and scraps of fabric, and other things she picked up along the way that she intended to turn into something (including a leaping horse with a saddle that at one time served on a merry-go-round).

Marissa took Maceo into the workspace, and showed him around, running her hands over some of her mother’s things saying, “This is where I remember my mom the most.”

Maceo said to her: “You make clothes?”

Marissa said, “She used to make *all* my clothes when I was growing up.”

Janie said, “All the quilts, too, knitted blankets, knitted baby clothes, sewed her dresses—you know back when she was little and let me dress her.”

“She didn’t make shoes, though. Those she had to buy,” Marissa laughed gaily, tossing her hair back, then crossing to the right side by the bedrooms. She put her hands on the master bedroom door saying, “This is where my mom and dad are,” stepping backward then and tracing a finger on the next door, “this is the bathroom,” then back another step, saying, “and this used to be my room.” She tapped a fingernail on the unicorn faceplate she got at a carnival one summer in Iroquois Falls. It bore her name spelled out in cookie jar letters. “And then over here is my brother’s room where you’ll be staying.” Now she opened the door to show him Evan’s room, and Maceo entered, towering over her daughter who watched up at him. She went in behind, leaning on the door, and Maceo stood by his luggage that John must have brought up here.

Evan’s room was deep and narrow; one side of the roof sloped, and his bedroom window was a dormer with a peaked alcove where Evan used to sit with a pillow and a blanket and read his Harry Potter books.

“It’s a very nice room. Very comfortable. Thank you,” Maceo said, looking up and around at all her son’s things while her daughter looked their tall, handsome houseguest over.



* * *

John was washing his hands in the sink when Janie came back down, saying to Roxy, “Everything ready to go?”

Roxy said, “More than ready, and if we don’t hurry up your husband is going to eat all the crab cakes.”

“What a snitch, Roxy,” he said, laughing and turning off the taps. He turned to see Janie eyeing him with her hands on her hips. Roxy was shrugging and smirking. He said, “One crab cake’s not going to ruin the party, Janie.”

Elizabeth was on the other side of the island, leaning on her elbows and nursing a red wine. She said, “Just one, John?”

Elizabeth was in her seventies now, a Vietnam era protestor and still-hippy revolutionary with long grey hair and hand-me-down clothes that were well-cared for but definitely vintage. “Another snitch. Isn’t it against your character, Lizzy? I mean, stick it to the man and all that, power to the people...”

Elizabeth said, “John, *you* are the man.”

“Oh no,” Janie said, knowing what he would say.

He lifted off the counter and took Janie in his arms. “I *am* the man.” Roxy snapped a tea towel on his ass but he ignored her.

“How many of my crab cakes did you eat, John?”

“They’re small.” Then turning to Elizabeth he said, “Janie’s the authority around here, Liz, man or not, aren’t you supposed to punch up not down?”

“You got me there, John,” she said, then to Janie: “I didn’t see a thing.”

He said, “Maceo like his room?”

“Of course. I think he’s a little overwhelmed, maybe tired. It’s a long flight. Let’s get dinner served so the kid can relax before he passes out.”

Roxy said, “We’ll eat, then I’ll get everyone out of your hair.”

Elizabeth said, “His English is good already, don’t you think?”

Janie pulled trays of mac and cheese out of the gas oven where they’d been warming. “What do you think, John?”

“Perfect English,” he said, twisting the cap off a Bud and tossing the cap in the trash.

“Then why are you trying to talk Italian?”

“What?” he laughed before he took a swig.

Janie said to the girls, “John’s picking up an Italian accent,” and they laughed.

He made an exasperated sound. “No, I’m not.”

Roxy said, “Maybe John’s got a crush on him.”

“That doesn’t even make sense, Rox.”

Elizabeth said, “Does he make you nervous, John?”

Now coming in from the dining room was Stacy Bernard—*Dr.* Bernard—Janie’s doctor and friend. The two of them were pregnant at the same time, Janie with Marissa, and Stacy owned a homestead with her husband a few miles down the road where they raised sheep. “John’s nervous?” she

said, one hand holding a glass of wine, the other snagging a radish rose from the veggie tray.

Roxy said, "John has a crush on Maceo."

"You're all idiots," he said as they laughed.

Stacy looked over her shoulder at Maceo who was engaged now with some of Marissa's college friends. "I get it, John. That's a good-looking kid."

"That's all man," Elizabeth said, eyeing him too.

"Guys, if you want me to leave, just tell me."

Janie said, "John, we want you to leave."

"And don't grab any more crab cakes on your way outta here," Elizabeth said.

Roxy folded her arms, looking over Liz's shoulder at Maceo and the girls. She said, "I had doubts about you doing a swap with Evan, you know—who's going to show up here? But, Janie, baby, if they're going to send tall dark and handsome, tell me where I sign up."

"I'm out," John said holding both hands up in surrender, one with the bottle sloshing Bud out the neck.

As he squeezed past them, Stacy said, "If I don't want to give up my son, you think they'll let me trade my husband?"



* * *

The meal was served buffet style, set up on the kitchen counters—their husky, Sheba, spending the party out in the heated barn so they could let their guard down. Everyone ate in their own groups, laughing and joking, everyone getting a chance to spend some time talking to Maceo (who was noticeably woozy). The girls hogged the dining room table, and one was always calling Maceo over to ask him something. Maceo liked the attention, she could tell. The others sat on the fireplace mantle or the bottom step of the staircase, spread out on the sofa and loveseat in the family room. She got around, moving from group to group and loved catching up with everyone. Since Mar had gone to college, the house had become too quiet. There had always been something going on in the Holcomb homestead, visitors, friends, the kids and their gangs, plus young people from faraway

places—but the kids were the magnets that attracted all the functions. With them grown up and out of the house she'd been reduced to the occasional visit with Rox for some gossip, or over to Liz's for a pot of tea. Stacy's younger sister had a surprise pregnancy and so there was a little one on the way, though Stacy's sister didn't live in Iroquois Falls—still it was nice to have that excitement renewed and she'd been knitting booties and a cap for the little baby that was due in about seven weeks.

John and his cronies disappeared into the addition once they were done eating, she imagined to watch football, and she began tidying in the kitchen. Marissa hopped in behind her to help, rubbing her hand on the back of her neck and massaging.

Mar whispered, "Oh, my God, Mom, I'm going to move back home for the semester—you don't mind, do you?"

"Don't take the Lord's name in vain, for one thing, Mar, and why don't you keep your mind on your schoolwork and forget about boys for now." She drew a few circles in the air before her daughter's face then wound it around in tighter concentric circles and booped the tip of her daughter's cute nose with the point of her index finger.

Mar rolled her eyes comically then closed them, smiled while her mother pressed on her button but said, "I'm an 'A' student, Mom, and your houseguest is a dimepiece."

"What's a dimepiece, Mar?"

"How many cents is a dime?"

"Ten."

"Maceo's a ten, Mom." She batted away the finger pressed to her nose.

"I don't think 'A' students say dimepiece."

"Does 'stud muffin' work for you? Is that what you used to call them?"

"*Them?*"

"Studs, Mom. Did they have studs back in the eighties?"

"Uh, the nineties, sweetheart, back when people apparently treated each other with more respect."

"I'm jo-king," Mar exhaled with another big eye roll, this time dipping at the knees.

"That young man is a guest in my home, Mar, so I don't need you skulking around making eyeballs at him or texting with your friends how he's a dime thing or whatever."

"Piece."

“Peace,” she said, flashing a hippy two-finger peace sign, saying, “Now get out of my kitchen, please.”

Nocturne

Marissa and her friends departed just after 7:30, six college girls cramming into one of her friends' minivan. It was an hour drive back to University of Buffalo and he worried about them driving in the dark. At least the roads would be clear.

Their daughter had surrendered her use of the Yukon she shared with Evan, both of them attending the same university. This home exchange had been her idea after all. Maceo wasn't exchanging with UB, he was going out forty minutes in the other direction to the art program at Chesborough, so the only way this would work was with a vehicle for the kid.

Once the girls were gone, the house went much, much quieter, and the energy began to deflate from the older crowd. Even young Maceo showed signs of wear, but of course he was jet-lagged, and had just endured a twelve hour flight and a couple hours holding up conversations in what to him would be a foreign language. His eyes had closed a few times, and Janie said she caught his chin nodding. Jason and Mitch and him had more cake out in the addition, then the three of them snuck out to the barn so Jason could smoke a joint and say hi to Sheba, bring her some leftover crab cakes and finger foods. When they came back in, Janie's crowd was packing up to leave. She and the girls had prepared doggy bags for Mitch and Jason and they took them greedily but with much thanks. It was early, and while he and Jason weren't jetlagged, they would both be at work before six in the morning.

At last it was the three of them alone in the house. The kitchen was tidied; the dishwasher hummed. Janie was happy and looked content—her party for Maceo had gone well. They introduced Sheba to Maceo, and he liked the husky, even getting down on his knees and roughing around with her a little. Maceo's shoulder bag was in the family room, and he'd brought gifts for them from Rome; some t-shirts and hand-painted ceramics, fancy olive oil, chocolate with hazelnut, earrings for Janie that Maceo's mother had picked out, and a bottle of limoncello for him. They sat at the dining room table and he wanted to pour the liqueur but Maceo said it had to be

cold so he put it in the pantry fridge. They sat and talked a while but all of them were tired.

Now Maceo sat in the family room, a sinking heap in a leather recliner, knees on those long legs level with his dozy chin. Janie was at the sink looking out the window at the deepening blue of the night. The kettle was boiling, a cup with a tea bag next to it. He kissed her neck just above the collar of her shirt. "You coming to bed soon?"

"Not till I hear Evan got there safe."

"Won't be till after midnight."

"I won't be able to sleep, anyway."

She was right about that. Janie wasn't an easy sleeper and she let worries work at her. He took her shoulders and massaged up her collar with his thumbs. Janie groaned and melted under his palms. "It was perfect today, Janie. Kid couldn't ask for a better welcome."

"Thanks, John," she said and stroked a palm over one of his hands. The kettle's lever snapped up, and the water churned to a steamy boil. She filled her cup.

"Night, Janie," he said and gave her one final squeeze before turning away.

Around the wood stove and its massive stone chimney he said to Maceo, "Hey, you made it, kiddo, you can go to bed now."

Maceo smiled, turned his face up to regard him. His eyes were heavy and bloodshot.

"You going to be able to make it up the stairs?"

"Yes, Mr. Holcomb, I—"

"John, Maceo, I warned you about that *mister* stuff."

"John," Maceo laughed and hauled his tall frame out of the comfortable chair, standing over John even though he was six foot. "Let me say good night to Mrs.—sorry, Janie."

John waited with Sheba at the bottom of the stairs as Maceo went around the stone chimney into the kitchen where he couldn't see them, spoke to Janie, then they both went upstairs, his dog trotting behind. "This is your room here," he said at the top.

"Yes, Marissa showed me."

"She did?" A protective rush swelled his blood vessels. *Was Maceo up here alone with his daughter?*

“Marissa and Jane,” he said, stepping into Evan’s room and switching the light on.

“Oh, okay. Hey, if it gets too hot you can crack the window open a little, but if you do, just keep the door closed so the heat doesn’t come up the stairs and shoot outside.”

“Okay, John, thank you. Thank you for everything. You’re so generous. It was a wonderful welcome.”

“Make yourself at home, Maceo. I’m out early in the morning but I’ll see you tomorrow night.”

They said their good nights, Maceo told him Janie showed him the bathroom, John made sure he had enough pillows and then left to get ready for bed.



* * *

Laptop open on her sewing table, Janie sat in the velour Queen Anne chair and knitted, keeping one eye on the screen. She’d left her browser open on a site that kept track of flights, waiting to see that Evan made it to Rome safely. He knew to text her as soon as he arrived and she’d sent a reminder, saying *text me your safe when u get in I don’t care what time it is*.

She was alternating from knitting to reading, taking a break when her knuckles began to ache, then picking up Stacy’s future-niece’s booties and resuming. It was a boon that a student like Maceo was here, and she looked forward to introducing him to the studio space properly. She’d taken him in tonight after the guests had gone to show him the space he’d have to work in when he wasn’t at college. He was so grateful and polite and fawned over her own paintings. But it was late, and he was tired and she didn’t know if his grace over looking at her work was honest or just good manners.

She’d never been to college, never got the chance. She was pregnant with Evan in her last year of high school. Even if she went, it wasn’t likely she’d have gone into an art program—she was kind of aimless back then. But in later years, after she’d got her GED, she’d become enamored with the idea of going back to school, maybe for art. She’d picked up painting again as a hobby (not that she had much down time with two babies and a homestead). More recently, since the kids were in high school, she’d gone

back to painting again. No more clothes to be made, or kids to be schooled, and eventually the kids' livestock were all sold off or passed away and her free time grew. When John built the addition, he put her in a studio space. Now she painted most days, had a group of women (and one man) who all met infrequently and painted or just drank coffee and talked about art. Last year, she'd even had a few of her paintings on display at the Iroquois Falls community gallery—though only one of them sold.

Across from where she sat, her tailor's dummy faced her, a headless mannequin with half a dress slung around it, something she was making for herself to wear this summer. The form was a little ghoulish alone at night like this, but now she could see in the standing mirror just behind it, sitting between Marissa's room and the bathroom, that Maceo slept with the door open almost a quarter way. Now she felt guilty about having the light on to read, and worried about the light of her laptop, too. But if it bothered him, he could close the door. Still, she reached up under the shade of the standing lamp beside her chair and pulled the chain to shut the light off.

She massaged her hand and stared at the screen of her laptop that seemed offensively bright in the new dark. She could go down to the kitchen or even the addition, but this was her spot where she liked to sit. It was warm and comforting. The heat from the fires below came up and made this room a sleepy sort of space at night time.



* * *

At eleven o'clock, the light came on in Maceo's room slicing a bright oblong slash in the open doorway. She blinked and looked around her sewing room, beginning to think she'd drifted to sleep while she waited. Eyes darting to the laptop she rubbed her cheeks; the screen had gone dim from not being used, but she could see Evan's flight was still in the air. Now she groaned and sat upright, pulling the bundle of knitting out of her lap and placing it on the felt top table next to her laptop.

The mirror against the wall had been placed there so she could get another angle on the mannequin while she tailored the dress, but from where she sat now she could see in the gap of Evan's open door Maceo sit

up in bed. She closed the clamshell lid of her laptop, worried he would look up and see her reflected in the mirror, her face lit up by the screen.

At first, seeing this young man sitting in her son's bed made her nostalgic, made her miss Evan and even more eager to hear from him. But her eyes grew wide, watching now as he looked around, his hair mussed and sitting on the top of his head in a jagged clump, then pulled his T-shirt up and off, tossing it to the floor next to the bed. It was too hot up here and the heat had congregated in Evan's room which often happened. A plain and pragmatic move on the young man's part and she felt suddenly lascivious being privy to a private moment like that, Maceo not knowing he could be seen. And that feeling of badness had been pronounced because in that moment where he removed his T-shirt, she had seen his bare body, could see the young perfection of him, the tight tanned skin, the way his muscle and sinew pressed up against it, the way it flexed as he struggled to get the shirt off. It was a violation to sit and watch, but she was transfixed and pinned here because to move now would give her away and she would be embarrassed, so she kept quiet, hugged her arms over her chest and sunk into the chair.

Maceo still sat up, and her eyes went over his body revealed from the sternum up. He had a hard and lean body, his arms were muscular but not pumped up, just defined and masculine. His skin shone with the heat. He obviously wasn't satisfied with removing his shirt, because he was looking around behind the headboard, eyeing the window set in the deep alcove of the dormer and considering opening it. She watched as he pulled the sheets away and swung his long legs out of bed and stood. He wore boxer shorts, his legs were tanned and showed off the movement of the muscle underneath just like his torso had. Then he was gone from her view, getting into the alcove. She heard the window slide open, watched the crack, waiting for him to return. Instead of reappearing and climbing back into bed, he was doing something else and her ears strained to hear. There was a snap of elastic, the sliding sound of cotton over skin, then he was in her view again, getting into bed naked. He'd taken his shorts off. In that sliver of lit space she watched now as he put a knee on the bed, saw the ridges of his ribs and the muscles of his waist flexing, his strong rounded haunch and rump. He had a perfect body and her eyebrows had wandered high as she didn't move her eyes away from the private, intimate view. His genitals were hidden, but she registered movement between his legs, registered the

tuft of his pubic patch in profile and then the movement of something dangling, swinging, thinking it must have been his opposite hand or something given the length away from his crotch. The whole moment extended over a mere second—a second filled with badness, voyeurism, shock, but also a certain humor. Also in that second, a thought spiraled up from the back of her brain, a prompt saying *Uh-oh, don't get back in bed without closing the door, John will be mad if all the heat from below went up and out that window, given how much it costs to heat the place, and how much time he spent stacking firewood*, and also in that moment the thought *John should install that ceiling fan at the top of the stairs like he said he would, push that heat back down so it doesn't wander up here in the first place*, and then as if in tune to her own thoughts, Maceo was pushing himself back up to stand, out of view again for a moment before appearing again fully frontally naked to her. The light was behind him as he filled the doorway gap, rim lit around his hair, one shoulder, his waist and leg. In the dim she could still make out the curve of his chest, light spilling over the ridged muscles of his side, the flat of his stomach and the dark tangle of hair below his navel and leading to a thatch between his legs. And between his legs she saw his penis. A dark shape, surely a trick to her eyes because it was so large, something huge swinging between his legs from side to side, the size of it surely an optical illusion, a normal size penis doubled because of a cast shadow... And then the door clicked shut.

The light from Evan's room still shone in a thin horizontal line at the foot of the door, but then it was out a few seconds later, accompanied by the squeak of the bed springs as Maceo got into her son's bed completely naked. Her heart pounded and a flood of shame washed over her as her brain began to consider how awful it would have been if he'd caught her eye in the mirror just now, watching him and not saying anything, watching from the dark. Her upper lip had gone sweaty, she could feel the chill of her rapid breath on it. Eyes wide in the dark, her hands opened and closed in fists, and blood swooshed in her eardrums like an ocean roar, her heartbeat pattering along.

It was just a naked body, Janie, no big deal. And you didn't get caught.
But why hadn't she looked away?

And why did she feel so strange now?—under the terror of potential discovery there was an unnamed rolling something, tumbling through her insides like a jagged ball of tumbleweed, scratching, tearing.

There was a time where she'd gone to the river down the valley below the property; it was summer, about five years back now, and she discovered Evan and his buddies frolicking in the water without their clothes, just being kids. What where they?—fourteen, fifteen? She'd seen all his friends' naked bodies, but it was cute and funny, and she'd backed away and then returned to the house before she embarrassed them all. There was no feeling like this back then, just laughter and sweetness.



* * *

Janie's hand woke him. In his dream-state, his mind struggled to make sense of the feeling of touch between his legs. It was his doctor at first, holding his testicles and saying it shouldn't hurt and he was saying *It hurts a little, but to be honest, you're a little rough, doctor*, but then it was him and Janie in the doctor's exam room, Dr. Greenwald had left them alone to discuss something important, and Janie held his testicles looking up in his eyes in that sweet way saying, *Dr. Greenwald is going to reverse your vasectomy, John, we're going to try again...*

"We can't, Janie," he groaned, eyes fluttering, and rolling to his back.

Janie kissed his shoulder.

When his eyes opened, all he saw was the bedroom's cedar strip ceiling that he put up himself. No doctor's office, no exam room. It was his wife's hand in his underwear, teasing his testicles and tugging on his pecker. He lay on his back, sleep drawing his mind to return to its warm embrace, Janie's hand encouraging him to the land of the living. Sleep's pull was strong because a few minutes ago it had engulfed him and folded him deep in its clutch.

Janie squeezed on the head of his cock, held his testicles in a clutch, pulled and stretched on his sleeping penis. Some excitement filled it, pumped volume to stretch it out and make it rubbery.

"What time is it?" he mumbled.

"It's early still," Janie whispered and kissed his shoulder again. She pushed the waistband of his underwear down under his testicles, squashing them up around either side of his penis. With the tip of her finger she teased

around the very point of his penis. He rolled his head to the side, registered the red diode display on the alarm clock.

“It’s after eleven, Janie.”

No answer, she just kissed his shoulder once more. So he lay there and drifted in and out while Janie’s hand played between his legs. At times he’d grow almost hard enough he thought he could roll over and do it but then it would fade. He had to be up to go to work in five hours.



* * *

John’s penis resisted her, but she persisted. She choked an OK sign under its head and gently tugged it upward underneath his belly. She’d like to intertwine her legs with his but Sheba was in the way, curled in a furry loop on the quilt, sleeping at the foot of the bed. His breath came slow and steady and she listened, hoping they would take on that lustful depth that would show she’d roused him.

He grunted. “I’m so full,” he said. “I ate too much of that cake.”

“You did,” she said, pressed her lips to his hairy shoulder. “And you drank a lot of beer.”

He groaned again and rolled her way but heaved a heavy arm over her. His penis pulled away from her fingers, folded up and swallowed away by the weight he’d put on the last ten years. She curled her finger in his waistband and snapped it up to cover his genitals again. She snuggled against him and he hugged her.

“I know you have to get up early,” she whispered.

Sheba groaned and stretched out. Both the dog and her husband’s breathing grew long and dozy and soon she was the only one awake in the room. She lay and stared at the ceiling till she was sure John was fast asleep again, then she carefully hoisted John’s arm off her and shimmied herself out of bed without waking him.

Closed in the bathroom, lights off to spare John’s sleep, she sat on the toilet with her chin in her hands and stared at the fuzzy towel hanging on the rack. No pee came, and she didn’t even remember why she’d come in here. Now her own breaths came slow and heavy and their languid sound saddened her. They grew shaky. They trembled. She struggled to keep them

quiet. Sobs came, dry and tearless, but tinted with her frail moaning, and soon she was racked with them, hunched over and blurting into her hands. Tears streamed at last, warm and wet and making her fingers slip together. Inexplicable sadness took complete control of her and she eased off the toilet to sit on the floor and cry fully into her hands with her panties twisted around her ankles.

When it was over she felt lighter, but bewildered. Her nasal passages were swollen, she breathed through her mouth in long, jagged pants, her tongue too thick for her mouth. The towel was pulled down as she dried her face and hands, sniffed and snorted, pulled up her panties, stood and stared at the pale ghostly reflection in the mirror above the sink. Eyes puffy, mouth hanging open, her hair was a tangled mess. She brushed it straight again.

“What was that about?” she sighed to herself and gave a soft laugh.

She slipped out of the bathroom, tiptoed through the bedroom and into the sewing room. Laptop collected, she made her way quietly to the top of the stairs, pausing at Evan’s door. In her son’s bed, Maceo would be sleeping, a young man in a foreign country staying with a foreign family, and soon her own son would be in the same situation. She rubbed her temples, staring at the closed door, then went quietly down the stairs and into the kitchen.

By the under-cupboard lighting she sat on a stool and continued her knitting. The radio was turned to NPR, her laptop was open. At 12:15, Evan texted her.

Evan: got here safe, mom! It’s beautiful and warm. I’m safe and in the car with Maceo’s parents. Hope Maceo is having fun (does Dad have him in a plow yet?) G2G but we’ll Skype later—go to bed!

She sent him her best, told him she loved him, he said the same, passed it on to his dad and sister, too. She told him she’d let them know. She shut her laptop, heart full and happy, snuck up to bed and was asleep before one o’clock.

Morning Routine

Morning routines were arranged to get him out of the house quietly and without fuss. No shower—he'd do that at nights—and down in the fridge would be a packed breakfast and a packed lunch Janie had already prepared for him. The coffee maker would've woken at 4:30 on its own and prepared him a pot. Janie would've left his clean thermos on the counter next to the coffeemaker.

But he was still in the bedroom, fully dressed in clean flannel and jeans, sitting on the bed watching his wife sleep while Sheba stretched and yawned and began her little dance, eager to get going. It was 4:50.

Janie slept peacefully on her side, curled toward the center of the bed where he'd woken to see her beautiful face. Her light blonde hair spread out on the pillow behind her like a billowing flag. She'd come to bed in one of his worn-out flannel shirts. It pooled around her slender frame, the unbuttoned cuffs in wide open envelopes around her fine wrists.

Sheba gave an irritated stress-yawn laced with a high whine and dragged her nails on the hardwood, stretching again.

"I'm coming, Sheebz," he whispered.

Jane's pouted lips were parted, she breathed through her mouth. Her eyes were closed, her long lashes jittered as her eyes darted back and forth and he wondered what she dreamed about. Last night he rebuffed her when she asked for sex. And there she was, a beautiful woman, and at one time she'd been a beautiful seventeen-year-old girl, the prettiest one in their school, and he would've given anything to be naked with her between the sheets. Now he was a tired man; tired and overweight and wasn't able to reliably get hard. It all seemed like the blink of an eye. It was just twenty years ago where they'd been so young and everything ahead of them seemed like an eternity.

He was careful not to wake her as he got over top of her and kissed her cheek. She stirred but didn't wake. When he rose, Sheba began her dance again, going around in circles, and he said, "I know, I know, we're going

already,” and opened the door before she made too much noise and woke Janie.

They went through the sewing room and past Evan’s room, the door open a crack, and he wondered how Maceo slept last night. Then he was down in the kitchen, taking out his packed lunch from the pantry fridge, pouring a whole coffee pot into his contractor-size thermos, throwing on his work coat, lacing up his boots, bracing himself for the cold. Sheba loved it, instantly leaping out the open door, jumping off the wraparound porch, running around in a circle, throwing her shoulder down in the snow and running with her back legs and shoveling with her face. He clapped his thigh for her, encouraged her to hurry up, walked around the porch and along the side of the house and down through the pathway toward the pickup truck. Sheba squatted for a pee.

He’d already hit the auto-start, and the F250 was up and running, its big diesel motor clicking away. He waited at the passenger side until Sheba came racing around the corner, and he held the door open so she could leap into the cab. Then it was just the two of them closed inside, the radio turned to the Wolf. Classic rock for the classic guy. He put it in reverse, did a three-point turn to get the F250 nose down on the hill and headed to work.



* * *

Maceo would start classes on Tuesday, but he had an appointment with the registrar at ten o’clock this morning. She planned to take Maceo to Rochester in the kids’ truck, show him the roads to get there, then she had some errands she could do and he could call her to let her know when he was ready to be picked up.

She was out of bed at six after tossing and turning in a light sleep once John had left the bed. One cup of coffee down, she switched to tea, brewed a pot and sat on the stool at the kitchen counter listening to the radio until the sun came up. The chickens needed to be woken and fed and watered, and she knew Maceo wanted to do that; or at least had expressed interest in it last night, and she didn’t think it was just out of politeness. He wanted the full experience so she would wait for him to get up.

When 7:30 rolled around, she knew she had to wake him. It would give him an hour to do the birds, eat breakfast, and have a shower because she planned to leave early in case there were any unexpected obstacles along their way.

Up the stairs, she moved quietly, paused at his open door. Thoughts of what she'd seen last night came back to her, but she flitted them away, blinking her eyes and physically shooing them with the backs of her hands. She tapped on the door with the point of her finger then pushed it open, saying his name softly. There was no answer, so she poked her head into Evan's room and saw the young man fully asleep in her son's bed.

There was something sweet about it, seeing him vulnerable like that. A very handsome young man, at peace with the world, his whole future ahead of him, flat on his back, one arm above his head, the other big hand opened on his bare chest. He'd closed the window again during the night and slept with only a sheet and a thin fleecy blanket. The quilt she'd made for Evan pieced together with swatches of his old dungarees was pushed down to the foot of the bed in a billowing cotton mountain range. The boy's big bare feet stuck out the bottom.

Before she even knew what she was doing, she'd walked the three steps to stand by his bed then sat down. She didn't want to creep the kid out, but she *was* going to indulge her inner mom whether he liked it or not, and she didn't care if he was twenty.

Now sitting close to him like this, those images from last night returned, and she made a funny grimace. It had just been his naked body she'd seen, but somehow the accidental exposure and her surreptitious spying made the whole affair seem lurid. *It was only a naked body.* But, she supposed, it was because he was a good-looking young man, tall and striking, and he did have an exceptionally beautiful body. *And a real live extra-large penis, something she had never seen before.*

Her eyes wandered over the exposed skin above Evan's faded chambray sheets. Maceo was olive-skinned, and it looked like he tanned back in Italy. She wondered if he ever went to the beach. It was supposed to be beautiful there, some truly breathtaking spots along the coast. Did he go there with his friends, did they play on the beach, how many girls were in love with this kid? His nipples were taut, dark brown quarters, and somewhere in Italy was a lucky twenty-year-old girl who'd laid in bed with him, put her mouth on them and felt their supple shape. Yes, Marissa's *dimepiece*. And

her daughter away at school would probably be equally intimate with young men with flawless youth and vigor—she didn't want to know, and prayed every night her daughter used protection. But the thought of her daughter that way lowered her brow; was she sleeping around? Was it terrible if she did? Her marks were excellent, and she had a level head.

Maceo's arm, extended up above his head, showed off his young, sinewy muscle. His armpit was alive with a bushel of wiry hair. His skin was flawless, not a mark. No moles, no flecks, just youthful beauty. His sleeping face was placid but his pouting lips hung open. They were soft and curled, almost feminine, but set on such a striking masculine face. Overnight she could see stubble had peppered along the angle of his jaw and up his cheeks.

She resisted the strong urge to give his thick head of hair a motherly tousle, but did whisper, "Rise and shine, sleepyhead."

His lashes fluttered before his eyes came alive. He blinked, turned his head on the pillow and regarded her with a slow smile creasing his cheeks. He began to stretch, flexing his muscles, the large hand on his chest closed in a fist, and he breathed deeply, his eyes on hers. She felt suddenly frozen in place, her eyes locked on his and she was unable to turn away. They were too close, and this was too intimate. It was unnerving but strangely compelling. She said, "I suppose they don't say that in Italy, do they? What would a mother call her sleeping son?"

He regarded her sleepily and yawned with his mouth closed. At last, he breathed in with a low, masculine sound, said, "A mother would say Vita Mia, it means My Life, like you are everything to me, you know...?"

"That's nice. Better than sleepyhead."

"But my mother she call *me* Patatino."

"And what's that?"

"Like, ah," he looked away, then darted his eyes back to her in a charming but embarrassed sort of way. "It means she call me her little potato. I was a Ciccibomba..." He winced then puffed out his cheeks, raked that big hand through his thick hair to clear it from his eyes, saying, "A fat kid."

"You were not," she laughed.

"Uh-ho," he laughed, "You ask my mother, she be happy to show you picture for proof."

"I might do that," she said, smiling and rocking back.

Maceo smiled at her, looking in her eyes, his hair sliding down and hanging to one side. She licked her lips, swallowed, and the sound was huge in her ears. She cleared her throat, said, "I've been waiting to do the chickens, would you like to come out with me?"

He sighed, flexed again, regarded her now through narrower eyes. "Yes, I would like that," he said and rolled to his side and propped his head in his hand. The sheet had worked down below his chest, and her eyes moved to look at the newly exposed ridges of ribs and his sternum.

She said, "I'll let you... I'll let you get dressed then. Meet me downstairs? We should leave in an hour..."

"Yes," he said, still watching her. He would be naked under those sheets, and she was still sitting here. He was supposed to get up, why was she still sitting here? When Evan was a little lad, he'd sometimes wake up with the blanket tented and she'd sit here and pretend she didn't notice. What might be going on under the sheets right now?—she shouldn't be so close to him when he was undressed and barely covered.

Now she was awkward, standing up, keeping her robe closed even though she wore a flannel shirt, pajama bottoms, and slippers. But she couldn't help a quirky weird smile from tugging up one side of her face. "Okay, right, you get to... Hey, if you don't have jeans, for, uh, chores, you know you can wear maybe some of Evan's old things, you can wear whatever you see in the closet there. Gosh, wait, you're a lot taller than him... Did you bring jeans?"

He was still smiling at her, confident and charming, laying in her son's bed. He said, "I'll find something to wear."

"Okay," she said, walking backward to the door, her heart starting to pick up its beat, imagining him now tossing aside the sheets and showing her what a twenty-year-old man looked like laying in bed. A wild thought hit her: would he be aroused or not? She closed her robe tighter, said, "I'll let you get to it, maybe you could wear John's boots—shoot, your feet are really big, aren't they?... Anyway, just, well, come down when you're, uh, dressed, and, uh, I'll find you some coveralls..."

He still watched her, seemingly amused at her awkwardness.

"Okay, we'll maybe get you boots at the co-op but, uh, just come on down when you're dressed." She backed herself out of the room, closing the door as she went, but leaving it a fist's breadth open. That was the way

she found it—but what if she opened it up again, right now? What would she see? *Holy cow, Janie.*

She closed the door until the latch clicked. “Good gravy,” she said to herself and rubbed her brow. She headed downstairs.



* * *

Maceo brought his own jeans though they weren't exactly what she would describe as farm-ready. They had fancy stitching and looked more like something he would wear to a nightclub in Rome. But it didn't matter, she thought, because she was sure she had a pair of coveralls that would fit him.

They went in the closed space of the mudroom that opened out to the wraparound porch on the side of the house where steps down led to the path to the chicken house. Back when they had kids coming in and out of the homestead from distant parts, she would buy old work clothes wherever she saw them; at the Salvation Army, the Goodwill, the Bargain Barn. There hadn't been any young men who were as tall as Maceo but she was sure she had a well-worn set of faded green cotton coveralls in an XXL. While he'd dressed, she'd gone to the deep end of the pantry and sorted through old clothing she kept stored in Rubbermaid bins on angle-iron shelving and found the ones she was looking for. The size label was so faded, she wasn't sure if it read XXL or plain XL.

She watched him stretch his long legs into them and when he hiked them up to get his shoulders and arms shoved in, the crotch tugged up tight between his legs. While he struggled his arms into the sleeves, she could see the shape of his genitals like a big soft hump down one of the coveralls' pant legs. In just his jeans there'd been no bulge she saw (uh, why are you even looking, Janie?), but the tightness of the coveralls made his male parts prominent.

Now he stood and presented his hapless visage to her, arms out, showing the sleeves ending far above his wrists, the pants as well, like he was preparing for a flood. But if they could find a pair of boots for his big feet, it would do for this morning and keep his clothing clean. And he said the same: when she asked him if they were too tight, they both laughed at

the obviousness, but he assured her they would be perfect for the job. She pushed a pair of Evan's rubber boots toward him and caught him tugging at his manhood and wincing.

"We'll get you some work clothes that fit when we're in Rochester today," she laughed.

He smoothed his hands on the coveralls, sheepish being caught adjusting himself and her eyes were drawn down again, and from her angle she could see the bowed out shape of his penis, even the lip of its head.

"Try your feet in those boots," she said, averting her eyes again and feeling a wave of displeasure for herself.

They were snug and gave him a hobble but he assured her he would be fine in them, and she assured him she would get boots that fit, too, and asked his size. He told her American fourteen.



* * *

He came out with her to wake the chickens, shrugged into a too-tight work coat with sleeves that left a gap between the cuffs and his gloves. It was gray but light out, cold but not frigid, and they walked the plowed path between snow-covered gardens, and the empty pens where the kids used to have their goats and pigs.

The chicken house wasn't too elaborate, and not high-tech; just a wooden bungalow John built, sided with greying pine. It had two chambers and a penned-in run protected with a roof that extended over top. Heat in the coop was electric, but even still, the girls slowed down their egg production when the snow and cold hit. Maceo had to stoop when he entered.

She showed him where they kept the feed, how much the birds got, showed him the ones that had names, the egg layers. He said, "Why do some not have names?" and she drew a line across her throat. *We will eat those ones.*

They collected the eggs, washed the ones they would eat for breakfast in the kitchen sink, put the rest in the pantry for later or to be sold to neighbors, and he sat at the kitchen counter and watched her cook.

Scrambled eggs, pea-meal bacon, toast with butter and jam. He drank coffee, and she drank tea.

While she washed the dishes, he went upstairs and showered. When he came down he was dressed for his appointment at the school, and together they went into the kids' Yukon. She showed him all the vehicles quirks (it was almost ten years old); how the stereo worked, how the CD didn't run anymore but how he could plug in his phone if he liked; how to put on the cruise control if he wanted it; told him it had high mileage but was safe and had good snow tires; she warned him about the steep driveway, how it could get slippery. John kept it maintained personally, and while they drove out of Iroquois Falls, she told Maceo all about the plow business. How after high school John went to work there, and they rented this farmhouse while she raised Evan. Then two years later there was Marissa, and they saved and saved and saved. John was a hard worker. Twelve-hour days were the norm, especially in winter. A lot of the times it was seven days a week, too, but it all depended on the weather. They had two fleets of plow trucks now, one for Rochester, one that went out west toward Buffalo. Plows were a hard business. A lot of work. They had fourteen employees, six Mack trucks, she wasn't sure how many pickups, and when it snowed John was like a ghost around the house. Maceo asked about the summer, and she said he did grounds maintenance but it was just to keep his hands busy; she told him he used the trucks for haulage, too.

She said, "John keeps these roadways clear so the people can go to their job or to church, or the hospital," and Maceo said, "*All* of them?" She said, "Well, not *all* of them. He doesn't have the contracts for the highways, he's not quite big enough. The bigger companies will sometimes subcontract him to do the highways on the snowiest days, but he has contracts with some of the counties. He has to make money everywhere he can, it's not so easy, and there's competition..."

"Competition?"

"As John would say, there's always some Joe Jerk-off with a pickup truck who gets a vinyl sign for the side door, puts a plow on it and starts undercutting guys who have serious businesses. There's not a lot of margin for profit but it gets better year after year because he keeps growing..."

Maceo said, "What's a Joe Jerk-off?"

“Oh, a bad name. Something I shouldn’t have said. It’s rude.”



* * *

Before she knew it they were seeing the first signs for Rochester. It was her old hometown. The place where she’d grown up. He asked her where. The suburbs, she told him. North Chili, exactly. Her and John. It was where the college was, though it was in a part of Chili that she didn’t know very well, and the campus was secluded from the road, hidden in a patch of woods.

They drove past her old high school, Wheatville-Chili, and she’d taken that route by choice, a detour because they had some time to spare. It was the first time she’d passed in a long time; usually when she’d come to Rochester, she went right in on the 490 and skipped Chili altogether.

Between the road and the school was a vast snowy field, the geometric shapes of the senior high poking up like pale brick icebergs in the distance. She said “This field here that’s all snow, that’s where John used to play football.”

Maceo looked past her, taking it all in with wide eyes. “Just like on TV. Friday Night Light.”

“You watch that?”

“My sister watch.”

“Yeah, I guess like that,” she said, as they passed. There were a ton of memories coming at her now, and she was smiling.

“He play football, you were cheerleader...?”

“Good question, Maceo,” she said, impressed by his grip on the culture and language. “No, I was not a cheerleader. I did not like the girls that were cheerleaders.”

“But you like football player.”

“Yes. One. But it was more like he liked me, I didn’t go after him.”

He laughed, swept his hair back up on to the top of his head, slouched in the passenger seat with his long legs folded up even in the spacious cabin of the truck. He said, “That’s the way it should be, yes?”

“I think so,” she laughed. “No, I mean, I was in love with John at high school, but I didn’t go chasing after football players.”

“Si.”

“John and I were just...” she laughed again, looking up at the sky, feeling good and smiling, “we were just right for each other.”

Now they were slowing, coming into the developed area of Chili, where the 33 started to be referred to as Buffalo Road, and there were plazas on both sides, a sign up on a marquee indicating one unit amongst a dozen: Marco’s Pizzeria. The place where she and John would come to eat during lunch break maybe twice a week, driving from Wheatville-Chili in his old Nissan pickup. She was rubbernecking, looking left and right, bunched up in traffic slowing for the traffic light ahead. It hadn’t been twenty years since she’d last been here, but it felt like it today; felt like she was passing through a portal into a different time. Most of the storefronts were the same, and as they passed through the lights, she saw a coral pink-painted house, a cottage really, a sixty-year-old throwback probably to a time when Chili was just a rural intersection. This tiny pink house set back from the road looking out of place amongst the big parking lot plazas and fast-food joints was still Rosa’s Salon after all these years. Her head was on a swivel as they passed, looking out Maceo’s window, then behind as she continued on.

Maceo asked her, “Did you study art in high school?”

“I had art in high school. I didn’t take it as seriously as I should, but it was my best grade... But I never did anything with it after that.”

“You do, you paint now.”

“I never did anything after high school... I never studied at college.”

“Your paintings are beautiful.”

She rolled her eyes like Marissa would. “Thank you,” she said and wobbled her head on her neck, unsure how to take a compliment. “Do you really mean that?”

“It’s true. When we go home, do you think we can paint?”

The college entrance was ahead now, the long brick sign with the brown metal letters spelling out Chesborough College mounted on it. She flicked her indicator, slowing. “We can if you’d like to,” she said. “Is that what you want to do?”

He was nodding as she pulled in and ascended the long sloping drive lined by trees. He said, “I don’t know how long the meeting is going to be, but maybe before John gets home...?”

She said, “I’d love to. John probably won’t be home early, anyway. We’ll have a few hours.” Her hands twisted on the wheel with a tight grip.

The college was ahead, students hustling now with their parka hoods up, trying to get from building to building without freezing. This had been in her hometown her whole life and she never thought about it. A top quality art school with an instructor inspiring enough she lured a young, talented man all the way from Italy. She pulled in, looking up in awe at the old architecture mixed with the new; modern cantilevered vestibules merging into old brick buildings that looked like churches. A real genuine spark of excitement sizzled in her bed of ashes. And she was smiling again, wide, *very* wide, and she couldn't stop it.

Hometown

First thing Maceo said when she picked him up was about her hair: “Janie, look at you, what did you do?”

He was sitting in the passenger seat pushed all the way back as if he wanted to take her whole visage in, cheek propped in the palm of his hand, elbow leaning on the door sill. His smile was wide and his eyes sparkled.

She hadn’t expected such exuberance and now she was self-conscious. “Is it okay?” she asked, moving her hand up to idly stroke at her hair.

“Okay? It’s beautiful, Janie. Look what it does for your face,” and now instead of leaning back he was leaning in, moving close to her in the cabin of the Yukon.

Now that self-consciousness was amplified, and she felt a static tingle in her fingertips and a creeping feeling along the backs of her shoulders. Had she made a mistake? She didn’t even know how it happened, but she ended up at Rosa’s, sitting and reading a Vogue and waiting to see if they had an opening; they did, and they ushered her in and now her plain-Jane long hair had been transformed into something the young girl (God, she said she was Rosa’s daughter!) called a ‘Julianne Hough’ and she didn’t even know who that was. Her hair had been washed, rinsed, color-enhanced, and cut in angled layers, leaving long bangs that she could still tuck behind her ears.

Maceo regarded her carefully, measuring the angles of her face with his artist’s eye.

“Are you sure it’s okay?” she asked again timidly.

His hand came up, moving slowly, eyes not on hers but watching her face, studying her. He said, “It’s beautiful, it really is. How did you do this? I thought you went to the big store to get things for John.” He had a lock of her hair, and his thumb stroked at it. She could feel the gentle tug of his pull and could feel the warmth of his hand near her neck.

She said, “I don’t know what happened. I don’t know what came over me. I went to the Costco, I bought all, you know,” she thumbed toward the back seat and Maceo looked back. The rear was filled with rolls of toilet paper, detergent, paper towels, cleaning supplies, and odds and ends mostly

for the plow depots but some stuff for the homestead, too. “I was coming out of the parking lot and I was thinking of this little place where I used to get my hair done...”

“Ah, Janie, you treated yourself...”

“I don’t think it was treating. Was it treating?”

“No, not treating at all,” he changed his mind. “You’re being a woman.”

“A woman? That’s what women do, get their hair done?” She raised an eyebrow and set her eyes hard so he would know she was prepared to school him.

“No,” he laughed, “they do what they *want*. Then they have to find ways to explain it to men who can’t understand.”

Now she laughed too and felt easier about it. Both of them were facing out the front window looking at the snowy expanse of an athletic field that sat like an angled white sheet working up to the administration offices of the Chesborough College. Students passed by next to the car and Maceo’s hand still held her hair.

“You’re right,” she said, “I don’t have to explain myself.”

“You’re beautiful and you want to show it,” he said.

She didn’t know what to say, looking out the window still, licking her lower lip. Was that a compliment? Politeness? Or was it going too far? She turned to regard him, saw his charming smile and felt instantly disarmed. He was just a charismatic twenty-year-old kid. She said, “I can’t believe the place is still open. I haven’t been there”—now she didn’t want to say it—“gosh, maybe fifteen years.” *Yeah, more like twenty.*

“And you go for good memory,” he said, and he was still touching her hair.

She said, “How was your meeting?”

“It was good.” He let her go and sat forward. “Just paperwork, forms... And introductions—they had a student give me a tour.”

“What do you think?”

“It’s wonderful. I’m looking forward to it.”

“Did you get to meet that professor you came here for?”

“No. Adele Davis? No, she not here today, or she not around.”

They were quiet a moment. She said, “I suppose we should get going.”

He said, “You are going to take me to the plow company?”

That was the plan. They were going to drop off this load of supplies that she’d purchased on the company credit card. But she said, “Is it all right

with you if we just go home?” She wanted to add: ‘...*to paint*,’ but was afraid that his answer would be he’d changed his mind.

Maceo said, “No. I love to. I go some other time. We go home we could draw and paint...?”

“You still want to?”

His hand came up again, and this time curled over her wrist, her hands draped over the steering wheel. He gave her a little squeeze and shake, and said, “I’ve been thinking about it all day. Who wants to do paperwork? I came here to be an artist.”

“Right?” she said, looking at his hand and how large it was on her. “Who wants to fill out forms?” His knuckles were big but his hands weren’t beaten or hard. It was hard to define what their shape did to her but there was something so alluring about the color of his skin, the luster and the masculinity without being beaten.

“Let’s go home, Janie,” he said.



* * *

South of Buffalo, in Hamburg, he pulled into the TSC parking lot. Jason was there with a dump truck and front loader. The lot was small, and they had enough accumulation that the snow they’d pushed into a mountain needed to be hauled out, so the farm supply had more room for parking. Jason had two guys with him, Davis and Rico. While Jason manned the front loader, a ten-year-old tractor with shovel attachment, Davis was in the dumper, so Rico used Jason’s truck and plow to tidy up the lot and square some edges. On the radio, Jason had told him there’d been an accident and if John was in the area, could he come by. From the tone of Jason’s voice he knew no one was hurt, knew that it was serious, though, but there was some humor involved.

At the far left of the lot, he could see the dump and the front loader sitting idle. The dump was loaded to the top with snow, and he could see Davis in the cab give a wave. Rico sat in the passenger seat of Jason’s pickup and Jason leaned at the door side talking to him through the open window. The lot was half full, and customer cars avoided the corner where

the trucks were working. A long, metal trailer sat up on the walkway near the storefront, upside down and bent.

“Oh boy,” he said to himself as he came around in the F250, plow to plow with Jason’s truck. Jason walked to the window and John ran it down.

“What happened?”

“Don’t laugh,” Jason said.

“Everyone okay?”

“Don’t let Rico see you laugh, I’m mad at him.”

“What did he do?”

“Plowing with my truck, I got the hitch on the back, he backed it right up to where all the new trailers are on display...” Jason waved over to the far side of the lot where there was a neat line up of different size trailers. There was a gap where one was missing, and a section where a chain should hang, but instead it snaked loosely over the scraped down lot.

“Oh no,” John sighed.

“Oh yeah, John. Kid snagged the trailer with the hitch, he’s got my radio playing loud, he pulls it out of the lineup sideways and drags it across the whole lot. The *whole* lot.”

“Cheez,” he sighed. “And our name is on the side of the truck.”

“You want to laugh, though, right?”

“Yeah.”

“I got him so worried. He thinks you’re here to fire him, so play along.”

“You’re such a jerk.”

“Kid’s gotta learn.”

“How many items you snagged and clipped?”

“I do it anymore?”

“No.”

“‘Cause I was scared I was going to lose my job.”

“Alright, I won’t laugh. Should I rub my beard?”

“Do it. And shake your head a little, too.”

John played along, rubbing his chin, stretching his neck, shaking his head. Rico was sullen and hunched over, eyes darting up and then back down. “How much is the trailer?”

“Twenty-eight hundred.”

“I guess we’ll go insurance.”

“Yeah. Manager’s inside.”

“I’ll go talk to him.”

“He was laughing.”

“He knows we’re good for it. We’ve been plowing here for more than a decade.”

“Yeah, I know. I’m mad at Rico so just drag this out with me. He’s my responsibility.”

He fished out his phone from the pocket of his coat, checked the screen. “I was going to head home, get some sleep before the storms.”

“Sorry I dragged you out.”

“It’s all right. I should call Janie, tell her I’ll be home later, after dinner.”

Jason leaned his forearms on the lip, stretched his back. “She alone with that Maceo kid today?”

“Uh-huh. She took him out to Rochester, show him how to get to the school.”

“The two of ‘em, huh?”

“Just the two of them,” he said, getting the inference, irritated even though it wasn’t said outright. “She loves having young people around.”

“I know. Young people are fun. Kids. Twenty, though? A little old to be an exchange student.”

“Evan’s doing it.”

“Never mind me,” he said, tapping the door and stepping back. “Make your call. But go straight in to see the manager, don’t talk to Rico. I want him sweating for another ten minutes, at least.”



* * *

When they got back home, she went in the kitchen and boiled a kettle. Maceo brought in the items for Costco, put them in the pantry and then went upstairs to get changed. She texted John and said she wouldn’t be by the depot, asked how his day was going. He got back to her saying terrible. That Rico had ruined a trailer out at the TSC in Hamburg and he was still there, plus he had a few calls to do, had to go back to the shop, too. He said he called, but she said she mustn’t have heard it. John said he was going to be late.

She put tea bags in a teapot and filled it with boiling water and Maceo came down ready to paint. He wore a plain white T-shirt, and a pair of paint-spattered shorts. His legs were bare, but hairy and muscular.

“Let me get changed,” she told him, then went upstairs and put on her painting clothes—an ancient flannel shirt of John’s, and a pair of jeans. She decided to go barefoot like Maceo.

When she came back down, he wasn’t in the kitchen. There was one steaming mug on the counter and she picked it up, went through the hallway to the pantry and then through the doors into the addition. Maceo was standing by the easel she’d brought back from the school and set up for him. But he was looking at a painting of hers on the easel beside. A landscape; snow, farm fence, mostly sky; a dilapidated barn. Painted from a picture taken on her iPhone just a few miles from here. She came behind him, and he was undisturbed, his eyes still going over her work.

She said, “You still like it?” When she’d shown him around the place last night, he’d seen the painting and said it was beautiful.

He said, “I love the color. Or the lack of color. It says so much.”

“That’s just how I saw it.”

“I don’t know what you saw, but what you put down here tells me something. I feel like I know this place.”

“Yeah,” she said, “it looks like everywhere else around here.”

“That’s what you like to do? Landscape?”

“Yes. I can spend hours in here—it’s a great way to pass the time.”

He cocked his head, still looking at the painting. He said, “I don’t think your work is about passing time.”

“Well that’s what I do it for. Now the kids are out of the house, seems like all I want to do is stand in here and paint.”

“It’s not passing time, Jane. You look for something.”

She shrugged her shoulders. “What am I looking for?”

He turned now to face her, said, “You don’t know what you’re trying to tell everybody,” he cocked his head toward her painting.

“I’m glad you have such profound insight into my work,” she said and sipped her tea.

“Somebody do something with purpose, it deserves to be, uh, studied. No, uh, considered...”

She said, “Do you think this shows merit?”

“Merit?”

“Value. Worth.”

“Ability, for sure. And when you don’t think you’re just passing time, that’s when you *find* something...”

She set her tea cup down on the worktable next to a paint smeared pallet. She folded her arms and looked at her own work. *Merit? Ability?* It was just a painting that she’d done from a photograph. But then why did she take the photograph? Sometimes when she was in here, she felt like it was nothing but paint-by-numbers. Spending time painting like she was doing a jigsaw puzzle. But what if Maceo was right...? What if she took that photo because she saw something in that landscape. It wasn’t even just a painting of a dilapidated barn. It was mostly sky. And in the sky were a thousand brush strokes. Not just gray, but all sorts of bottle greens and cobalts. She spent most of her time working on the sky. The barn was just a series of strokes done with a thick brush then picked up with highlights using a fine sable point. She’d probably spent about ten minutes on the barn. But that expanse of sky...? “So what do you think—”

Maceo was gone, opening a two-pack of plastic-wrapped pre-stretched canvases.

“You’re going to paint?” she asked him.

“That’s why we here,” he said with a smile, his eyes turned down as his hands worked to pull free one of the canvases, a square, two-feet-by-two, then standing and placing it on his easel. Then he took the legs of the easel and moved it around thirty degrees to get better light. They would be working side-by-side.

She asked him: “Do you know what *your* message is? Do you know what *you* want to paint?”

“It’s always different. There always something that I want to say, I don’t know what it is when I start, but I do when I’m done. When it’s done, I put it out. And I wait for something else.” He took a pencil, held it loosely between thumb and forefinger, began roughing out shapes. She picked up her tea and stood behind him to watch, asking then, “Is it alright if I stand behind you?”

“I like it,” he said, and now his hand was moving with more flourish. Slowly the block shapes took form she could see with her eyes: a figure, properly proportioned, eyes then and a nose, all done without reference. She said, “I can’t draw figures.”

“That because you don’t think you can draw figures,” he said.

She said, "I don't think I can draw figures—and it's been proven."

He disregarded her, his hand still moving. In a few more minutes, she swore now that he was drawing her. She was sure when he began to flesh out with pastels her blonde hair shaped in her new haircut.

"Hey, you drawing me?"

"Is that okay? I like to warm up."

"I'm just a warm-up," she said, smirking then sipping.

His hand paused now, and he peered at her over his shoulder and cocked an eyebrow. She laughed.

"I don't want to gush," she said, "but you're amazing."

"That because I don't think that I can't draw figures anymore."

She wanted to poke at him amicably, kick at his leg, but his legs were bare and her feet were bare. So she just laughed now, turned and sat down with her rump against the back of the couch where John watched sports when he had the time.

Maceo stopped, said, "Janie, you need to come and finish painting."

"I've been working on it forever," she said.

"You lost interest?"

"No, I just don't know..."

"You're afraid it's done, afraid because you don't know what come next."

"No, it's not that," she said, but then began to doubt it. *Was that it?*

He looked at her painting again, turned to her and said, "It's done, Janie. It's done, but you don't know it. That's what the problem is. You said what you want to say, now it's time to move on."

"Is that it?" she said.

"I think so," he said.

"Well, if you're so smart then, tell me what it is I want to say."

"Pick up a new canvas," he said, "and get your hand moving."

"I need to go through some of my photographs..."

"No pictures," he said, setting a pastel down and taking up the second blank canvas from the package he'd opened. He removed her painting of the sky and barn and plopped the blank square in its stead. Now he held her painting in two hands and looked at it again. He said, "Janie, it's perfect. Time for new one. Come and sign this one and then move on."

It felt warm and friendly, watching this young guy working with her, wanting to communicate, trying to convey his own thoughts, his own young

ideas, wanting to befriend her and impress her. And she felt it, too: *camaraderie*. Was this what it would've been like if she'd gone to school? If she'd gone to college, studied art, would she have had a boyfriend like Maceo?—would they get an apartment together and paint? What would that have been like? She could picture it; wasn't like she hadn't thought of that sort of thing before. Actually finishing high school, being a free spirit whose only need was to find herself rather than breast-feeding her baby in this snowy farmhouse all by herself. But that built character, too. Made her who she was today, and she liked herself. It wasn't like kids that came out of those art programs were some kind of better beings. Most of them longed to find *her* kind of authenticity. Most of Marissa's friends admired her as a woman. She did have toughness, and a sense of reality. Maybe going to art school and hooking up with some well-hung Italian artist would've ended in misery. No money, no future, just a lot of fun and nonsense that amounted to nothing. She could only think of the lubricious times; and imagination was *always* better than reality. How often would she and this imaginary young artist have laid in bed listening to vinyl on phonographs, pontificating on Nina Simone, or blowing off a day of school to go to a protest or something? She didn't remember what they used to protest back when she was nineteen. Abortion? *Yes, you remember that.*

"All right," she said, and then pretended to crack her knuckles and stood up. "Let's paint."

Drawn

Sheba ate her can of slop at the depot because he wouldn't want her to go hungry on late nights, but he waited till he got home to eat rather than stopping at a drive-thru. It was just an extra cost and something about it was like stepping out; your wife at the homestead making home-cooked meals and you're out getting it on the side. Now it was almost eight, and he and Sheba were out of the warm pickup cab and shuffling the shoveled path between the snow-covered summer gardens, stepping up onto the wraparound porch. This is when he saw them.

Janie and Maceo ate together at the dining room table, the outside air around him a frigid, brittle blue, and his wife and their young, handsome house guest lit up in warm firelight amber. Right in front of him, like watching it all on a screen, a movie about a woman who looked just like his wife and she was out on a date. Their plates were half-finished, they each held gleaming forks and talked closely. Both of them had a glass of wine and there was a bottle on the table. Janie didn't drink, but the bottle was clear glass, the wine white, and he could see there was very little remaining. Janie wore an old flannel of his, which was nice, the one she used sometimes when painting; the sleeves were rolled up to her elbows, showing off the fine grace of her arms. Most striking, and instantly alerting: she'd done her hair. She was beautiful. A new cut, her hair straight and silky, but somehow layered in gentle hanging locks; gone was the tangled farmer's mane, the tortoise shell clips, the bun or horse's tail. Now she wore it down and it fell in a heavenly frame around her perfect face. No longer was it the silvering blonde, now she'd returned to the bright gold of high school, what she called 'champagne' when she was seventeen.

She laughed now at something Maceo said, lighting up, her smile wide and showing off her white teeth. Her cheeks had blushed from the wine. His stomach twisted at the sight, but for some reason he smiled seeing her like that. A hard knot of intertwined threads tightened somewhere below his heart; jealousy, love, nostalgia... He could picture her in his old truck, the ancient Nissan he had in high school with its lift kit and fat tires, she was

sitting in the passenger seat, correcting him with youthful charm and humor, the two of them just dumb kids, shaking her hair out and saying *Platinum, John?—it's called champagne, darling*, then she giggled at her own theatrical haughtiness.

They saw him through the windows under the porch light now. Maceo smiled and waved, and Janie jumped up and wiped her mouth with a napkin. She met him at the door.

"I thought you were going to be later," she cried, making a sad face for him. "We would've waited..."

He told her it was alright, and she asked him about the trailer and how the rest of his day went. He told her Rico was almost in tears but they finally let him off the hook. Said how Jason put the kid in a headlock and how he'd literally kicked the kid in the ass with his snowy boot. That was his punishment, not getting fired, they laughed, and told him fuck-ups were inevitable, but don't make them frequent. Janie got a kick out of it, she liked Rico, and Maceo laughed along.

"Sit down, I'll get your dinner," she said and headed for the kitchen but he grabbed her arm.

"We're not going to talk about this?" he said with a smile, darting his eyes up and around her new hair-do.

"Oh, I forgot," she said, then smoothed her hands over her hanging hair. "Do you like it?"

"You look exactly like you did in high school."

Drink had put a shine in her eyes and he could see them tremble for a moment like she might cry; her lips even tightened and wriggled. She said, "You don't think it's stupid?"

With unexpected force, his heart swelled in his chest. For a moment the hardworking, down-to-earth woman was wiped away, and he was face to face with the beautiful but unsure young high school girl he'd fallen in love with. "Stupid?—Janie, you look beautiful."

"I told her," Maceo said then sipped a glass of wine.

John said, "Did you guys go together?" Now he could picture this Italian kid in the Yukon with her today, seducing her and talking with his hands, telling her all the fashion in Rome and how the ladies were doing their hair this season.

Janie said, "No, I didn't even know I was going to do it. Maceo was at the school and I went to the Costco—"

“They do hair there now?”

“No—remember the salon on Buffalo, across from the Walgreen’s?”

He shook his head no.

Now she admonished him with a look that said *Men!* and said, “In Chili, John... Well, anyway, that was where I used to go back when I lived there, and it was *still* open. I couldn’t believe it. Next thing I was pulling in and sitting in a chair.”

He nodded, his mind fixated on the use of the personal pronoun ‘I’: *I lived there?*—Janie, *we* lived there, *we*. But his smile came again, even after hearing his wife’s inadvertent statement of independence, because of Janie’s eyes. Glassy yet *alive*.

“I’m just not used to doing something like that,” she said, touching her hair again, lofting it with one hand and heading to the kitchen. “Have a seat, John, I’ll bring your plate.”

He sat across from Maceo, coming down heavy and tired in the creaking chair while Sheba trotted into the family room and curled up on her dog bed. “How was your day, Maceo?” he said and rubbed at his cheeks and eyes.

Maceo told him about his trip to the school and Janie returned with a plate of roast beef and carrots and potatoes and green beans. They finished eating, Maceo and Janie first, then waiting for him; Janie cleared the plates, and he took his work clothes to the mud room.

Maceo was behind him, pausing in the space by the pantry between the old house and the addition. “Do you want to see?” he asked.

“See what?”

“The painting...”

“Right,” he said and nodded drowsily—they’d told him they’d been painting in the afternoon.

Maceo led him into the addition; the lights were on the low setting of the dimmer and a fire had been made but now dulled to a bed of skeletal coals that hummed in orange. Maceo drew the lights up with the slider on the switch, and John followed him to his wife’s space that was filled now with two easels. On the left was a landscape, the painting on the right was obscured by obtrusive shine—the angle of the overhead halogens making a glare. The painting on the left was one of Janie’s, he was sure of it. Not the one she’d been working on the last few weeks, this was new, or at least new to him. New, but similar.

Behind him, Janie's voice, timid yet anxious: "Hey, what are you two doing?"

"This yours?" he asked, looking over his shoulder to see her coming into the addition now, her brow furrowed.

"Yeah, you guys come in here without me?"

"You're here now," he said.

She came to stand beside him and he put his arm around her waist; she leaned her cheek against his chest. He kissed the top of her head and smelled that weird salon smell and the floral scent of conditioners overtop.

"What's it going to be?"

"I don't know yet," she sighed.

"Is it a barn?" he asked.

She shrugged.

The painting was unfinished, just a field of abstract shapes and the beginnings of a horizon line; above the horizon line, which was low on the canvas, a sky was taking shape and it looked like a doozy of a storm coming.

Janie said, "You should see what *he* did."

"What did he do?"

Maceo waved his hand like this wasn't supposed to be about him. Janie said, "Go, Maceo, show him," then looking up, she said, "John, he is incredible."

"Janie is the artist today, but this is what she talk about," Maceo said, lifting the other canvas off the easel with one hand and holding it low so John could get a look at it.

He was instantly flabbergasted. For whatever reason, he'd expected a landscape, something like Janie had done, but here he was presented with the unexpected. He stepped back as if in shock.

"Janie, that's you..."

"Isn't he amazing?" She hugged herself to him, admiring the kid's painting of her along with him.

On the canvas was an incredibly real painting of his wife. It was her like he'd seen her today, with the new hair, but it was more: it was Janie of his memories. Young Janie, eyes alive, sparkling, he'd captured that mirth she put around herself like a cloak, this gentle emanating spirit, an endearing one, but one that also told you there's more going on behind those eyes, a mystery; he'd captured the unsureness she had, the confidence overtop, a

little pigtail girl still underneath clutching her grip to something stable while the world spun around her.

All he managed to say, in a soft whisper: “What...?”

“It’s all pastel,” Janie said. “Isn’t he amazing, John? Honestly...”

“He is,” John said absently, unable to break eye contact from the drawing of his wife.

But now a nauseous feeling grabbed the sheets and rolled over in his stomach, leaving him cold and uncovered. The way he’d seen them eating together like they were dating, the two of them alone all day, this drawing. Janie had posed for him sitting somewhere and smiling like that, showing him her truth with her eyes. “Did you... *pose* for him?”

She said, “No, I didn’t, he just...”

Maceo said, “No, it from memory.”

“She didn’t pose?”

“I was behind him when he drew it, just watching.”

“Are you kidding?”

Maceo said, “It simple, the drawing, but if she sit, I would like to paint her...”

“This is simple?” he said, hands pushed into his pockets to stop from reaching out and grabbing the painting.

Maceo said, “You like it?”

“Maceo, I, uh, I can’t believe it. Like it? I *love* it. I mean, look at her. That’s *her*. That’s Jane.”

Maceo thrust the canvas forward. “You like it, it yours.”

“Really?” His hands darted out of his pockets eagerly.

Maceo drew the canvas back against his body. “Leave it with me and I finish it.”

John said, “No, no, no way,” reaching forward and taking the canvas with both hands. Maceo surrendered it, and John held it out to admire. “It’s perfect the way it is. Perfect. I like the way it’s just her face, you’ve done it... I mean, that’s Jane. God, look at her.”

“Oh, John,” Janie sighed, exasperatedly, but rubbed her hand in a circle over his back.

He said, “You didn’t look at her?”

“No,” Maceo said.

“Her face is beautiful and then everything else around her is unfinished. I don’t know... I want it like this. Exactly like this...”

“It’s yours,” Maceo said, giving a polite head nod and smiling.



* * *

Afterward, John asked them if they wanted to paint some more while he watched TV, but they both said no. The brushes had been cleaned and their things put away. She had breakthroughs today, breakthroughs she didn’t even know she had in her, but now her creativity was like the open mouth of a cave after its dusk-time flock of bats had flickered their leathery wings into the night and left it yawning blankly. Nothing more would come. Tomorrow would be another day, and just doing what she’d done on that canvas already left her tired. She knew what she wanted to do—not on the canvas, but with the way she would approach it. She wanted to wait, and she would follow that intuition.

So John sat on his couch with his back to the painting side of the addition and watched the news. She joined him, sitting next to him on the other side of the couch. Maceo retired for the night, and they wished him well and said they’d see him in the morning. John dozed off, and she unfolded a blanket from the arm and draped it over his lap. She took the beer bottle from the side table and rinsed it out in the sink. Sometimes when he fell asleep on the couch, it was better to leave him than to rouse him and send him to bed. He claimed he got a good sleep there.

Upstairs, she stopped at Maceo’s door and listened. She could hear him in there talking, assumed he would be on the phone. Just his quiet voice, soft sounds of Italian behind her son’s door. She avoided the urge to push it open further and wish him a good night. *Just leave him be, Janie.*

She gathered up her knitting and took her spot in the Queen Anne’s chair, turned her lamp on and picked up where she’d left off. Fifteen minutes later, John emerged in the stairwell, flicking off the lights behind him, coming up into the sewing room. He was standing in front of the mirror that was still angled toward Maceo’s door, and she caught her eyes trying to work around her husband like she might miss something.

John said, “I’m getting in the shower. How about you come to bed?...”

She said, “No, I want to do some knitting. I’d like to finish these booties and a blanket this week,” she said, holding up the tangled wad of knitting

from her lap and then patted the book on the side table, saying, “and I want to read my book. I’m not even tired.”

He looked at her strangely, cocking his head from side to side, said, “Alright, I’m going to get cleaned up.”

A minute later she heard doggie footsteps coming up the stairs and then Sheba joined her, passing by for a head scratch before retiring to their bed.

Maceo was quiet for a long while, then later she could hear him talking again. *Who was he talking to?* She did some quick math and figured it must be three o’clock in the morning in Rome. Who was still up there?—it would be Tuesday morning. Who was up at that time on a Tuesday morning? She supposed twenty-year-old Italian girls probably were. Especially to receive a phone call from handsome Maceo.

The master bedroom door opened again, John was in the doorway in his boxers and a loose T-shirt. One callused hand scratched at his chest. He said, “You sure you’re not coming to bed?”

“I will soon,” she said, “it’s early for me.”

John watched her for a moment, strangely again, maybe slyly. He said, “Good night, Janie. I love your hair.”

She said, “I’ll see you in the morning,” and John went to bed.

A light switched on in Maceo’s room, and her eyes were drawn up to the mirror but the crack was too narrow. She could see part of Evan’s Tyrod Taylor poster, could see the dark blue paint on his wall. A shadow moved, but she didn’t see Maceo.

She ignored it, returned to her knitting. Maceo was on his phone again and he must be walking around the room. She could hear the creaking of floorboards, could see the moving shadow in the gap of his open door reflected in the mirror. He was talking to someone in Italian. It must’ve been a girl because she could tell by his charismatic patter. A lot of *Si, si, si*, and he was using a low voice, a masculine voice. Now she was smiling, her knitting needles clicking away.

Maceo made an exasperated but comical groaning sound. Then: “In English, *si, yes*,” he said as if the girl he spoke to was admonishing him. Now he was speaking English to her. “I told you,” he said, “it’s a big place, the space is bright, the people nice....*si*, I go, no, she not there, but she there tomorrow....*si*....far,” then he laughed, “but they give me car, no, no, truck,” laughing again, “big truck...”

The bed springs squeaked as if he'd plunked himself down. His voice became a low murmur.

She set her knitting down on the sewing table, got herself quietly out of the chair and moved in her slipper socks toward Evan's door, her eyes on the mirror. When she was close, she stopped to listen.

Maceo said, "We came back later....then I paint....No, the family where I'm staying, the wife she paint too..."

She cocked her head to angle her ear toward the gap in the open door.

Maceo said, "No, she paint good....Paints *well*, si..."

That made her smile.

"She's very nice....Oh, you think so?" Now he laughed. "She *is* very pretty." He said this as though it was a warning to whom ever he was talking to.

There was a long pause as he listened to the girl on the other line. Now he was laughing again, saying, "We'll have to see, you be good to me, yes?"

Her heart was hammering, and she felt guilty. It was nice to hear him say sweet things about her and about his stay here, but she was definitely spying and she shouldn't be. But now she was afraid to move away. Afraid that if she stepped back, the floor would creak and he would know she'd been eavesdropping.

There was more squeaking bed springs as if he was laying back. "She is....blonde, very pretty, *beautiful*....You jealous?" He laughed again. "She's very nice, very good to me." He made an exasperated sound, said something in Italian. More laughing, and he resumed speaking in Italian.

She stepped back, still listening, wanting to hear more, but she should get away while he wasn't speaking English, anyway. Then she heard the traditional: *ciao*. She stopped where she stood. She was only two steps back from his door. The bed springs squeaked again, and she could hear him moving around. A drawer opened and closed, and a lightning fast urge to head down the stairs as if she'd got up from bed to go down to the kitchen to get a drink of water whipped through her, thighs flexing as she moved toward the top step, but the sliver in the gap of the open door went dark and she sighed relief.

As her muscles relaxed, and she exhaled silently, she instead eased herself backward, intending to return to her chair. The door opened and Maceo stood in the dim just two feet from her. He was completely naked. She jolted like an electric current passed through her but remained frozen in

place, aware of her soft but heavy breaths scoring through her hung-open mouth; her fingers tingled and her palms had chilled with damp, a prickly sheet of shame crept down her back.

Maceo was calm, expressionless, standing still and regarding her. The weak ambient light of her sewing room caressed all the edges of his body, picked him out as a paler shape against the black of her son's dark room behind him. It was like he *allowed* her to appreciate his body, and now her eyes roamed while her arms and legs had gone rigid and immobile.

He was so tall, her eyes level with his chest, his hard and young and masculine torso flexing before her eyes as he breathed calmly. But her eyes fell low, down between his legs, moving up and down over the big penis that dangled there below a thicket of his pubic hair.

It hung down more than double the length of his testicles, a sagging, heavy thing with a bell end on it that looked as big as a chicken egg; it was pendulously mesmerizing, swaying from side to side. A squelch of Mar's leftover guacamole dip she'd served with dinner burned her an inch below her sternum; the thing between his legs should have been revolting to her but her eyes wouldn't leave it; her knees trembled and at first she thought it was fear that he would condemn her for looking at it, but as heartbeat after heartbeat her quivering eyes never left him, she realized a foreign, roaring, uncomfortable feeling roused deep within her, and the whispering word *lust* echoed in her mind. This was lust; primal sexual impulse.

The moment was long and awkward and agonizing. His eyes stayed steady on her. Instead of stepping back, maybe bringing both his hands down in a quick gesture to cover his nakedness, she watched the slightest smile pull up on one side of his cheek. At last, he motioned with his hand out into the sewing room saying, "I was going to turn out the light."

Mouth opening and closing, but no sound coming except for a tense creak in the hinge of her jaw only she could hear, she struggled for something to say. "I, uh, s-sorry, I-I'll turn it out..." And then her mouth stayed open because there was more to say but she had nothing again, her heart beating faster and faster and this awful whooshing sound in her ears. He continued to regard her, almost amused, and her eyes went down over his perfect form and between his legs again, then back up. She said, "I was going to make... some tea—you want, uh, do you want some tea?"

Still standing there as if he wasn't completely naked he said, "It's late for tea, Janie."

“Yeah,” she said, struggling to swallow. “I suppose.”

He shifted, one hip going out, his cock swaying; the door opened wider and so did her eyes. An invitation—she swore it was an invitation, a gesture to allow her access to the room, to come in and join him; the smallest of movements but loaded with perceived meaning.

“Oh, no, oh, okay, I, uh, good, um, good night, Maceo,” she stammered, hands shaking, stepping back into the safer perimeter of her sewing room, watching the young handsome man still regarding her from the open doorway. “Good night, Janie, I see you tomorrow,” he said and smiled.

“Yeah, see you tom—see you in the, uh, the morning...”

With that, Maceo closed the door, and she was alone in the safe space, heart whooshing in her ears, deafening, her knees gone weak, her ass muscles gone into tremors and her stomach feeling light and airy and pushing gently up against her organs. She continued her path backward, coming to her chair, her calves pressing against its front face. She plopped down heavily onto it, eyes still on the closed door, watching it again in the mirror she’d angled for the purpose of dressing her tailor’s dummy.

Sure, that was why it was angled that way. Sure.

Elbows on her knees, she buried her face in her sweaty palms and could feel the horror taking over, consuming her now, flooding up from her core and hacking through her like with a scythe swung in crescents. She was ashamed, embarrassed, *loathsome*. A peeping tom. An old woman spying on a young man; she’d sat here half-heartedly knitting, waiting to catch a glimpse of him naked again. And she did. All that good built up during the day, almost a friendship, just whacked on the footing and the whole beautiful day came down like a Jenga tower.

“Oh, no, oh, why, Janie? Why did you do that?” she cried.



* * *

Janie changed her mind and came to bed. He’d fallen asleep but woke with the feel of her sliding in between the sheets next to him. Half asleep, he rolled over to meet her.

“I was hoping you were going to come to bed,” he murmured.

“You’re still up?” she whispered.

“I was waiting for you.”

“I thought you were sleeping.” Her voice sounded tight, constricted.

“Come here,” he said, hooked his forearm around her waist, and pulled her closer. But instead of turning to face him, putting her face up by his, she squirmed to face the opposite way, giving him her back. It felt good to have her body pressed to his, to feel her lithe frame rubbing against him. He brought the center of his hand up to her chest, put his mouth on her neck and kissed.

She whispered, “What are you doing?”

“I turned you down last night.”

“You did.”

There was that tension in her voice again, a tightness that raised her whisper to a high sound. Her body was rigid under his touch. “Are you shaking?”

“Am I?”

It felt like her body was trembling, he could feel it along her sides, and against the inside of his arm. “You don’t feel cold,” he said.

“I think I have a chill.”

“Coming down with something?”

It took her a moment to answer, and he thought maybe she’d not heard him or drifted off. “Maybe,” she whispered at last.

He brought his hand down the center of her body, going up over her hip and down her thigh. He could feel her grace under the cotton flannel of her pajama bottoms. His hand swooped back up the front of her thigh, resting now across her stomach below her navel.

He kissed her ear again, but she said, “Is it okay if we just don’t?”

“You don’t want to?”

“Is it all right if you just hold me?”

“I’ll hold you,” he said. He didn’t like letting her down the night before, but if she wasn’t in the mood, she wasn’t in the mood. And he did have to get up early—they had a lot to do to prepare for the storm.

The hand on her stomach came up, higher than her breasts, up to her collar and he wormed his fingers to fit in the space between her neck and the pillow. He wriggled closer, shifting his hips, and Janie did the same, pushing her rump back against him. “I love you,” he said.

“I love you, too, John.”

In five minutes he was asleep.

Discovery

Nothing was said the next morning about the naked encounter and for that she was glad. She made Maceo his breakfast; he went and did the chores on his own while she cooked. They ate together but were quiet, friendly enough, though, and then he went upstairs to shower. She asked him what he wanted for lunch and he wouldn't hear of it saying, "No, I get something at school." That night he came home at six, and John was home at seven. They didn't have time to paint, and she was disappointed. During the day she'd stared at her canvas, but now nothing was coming to her. She had other things to do, anyway, so she did those instead. It was the same thing on Wednesday, the same thing on Thursday. Wednesday he came home *after* John and said that he went out after classes with some friends he made at the art program. It wasn't late, she was happy for him. On Thursday, John was later, so she and Maceo ate together at the dining room table. That was last night. He'd said, "Tomorrow I'll be home I think around two. Will you paint with me?..." She'd nodded silently, but couldn't help smiling.

Now it was Friday, and it was half-past one, she was sitting at the dining room table waiting for him to appear around the corner, waiting for that tall good-looking guy to come up her snowy walk and join her in the studio. She'd showered, washed her hair, dried it, done everything she could to bring it back to the way she'd walked out of the salon on Monday (though it resisted her), finally found a way for it to look flattering again. Lip gloss was applied; she'd tried a bit of old makeup, and even went into Mar's room to grab a few of her leftover things, but ended up wiping it all off. It looked out of place. Besides, she never wore makeup. That wasn't her. And all she wanted was for him to come home so she could paint with him. That's all it was.

So her fingers wove together, and once it passed two o'clock those fingers began to wring together and hurt. She twisted them around, brow furrowing, imagining Maceo heading home and a group of girls from the college intercepting him enjoining him to come out with them for a little bite to eat, hang out for a while and talk about art. Bare feet bouncing on

the floor she watched the window, sadness creeping up her back. All alone again in the homestead, sitting at the table in her best old jeans and her painting flannel, afraid if he didn't walk around the corner soon she would never be able to paint again...

And then there he was. Tall, handsome, happy. Her heart lifted, and she smiled and waved. He met her eyes the whole way, coming up between banks of shoveled snow that lay over her summer gardens.



* * *

Light came in the studio windows, flooding the space with a dull coolness that made almost no shadows. The landscape outside the windows glowed in a strange otherworldly gloom; the snow shone bright with reflected sun from an unseen bright sky somewhere to the east side of the addition, the house side where there were no windows, but the valley and the hills beyond looked black and jagged against the cushion of settled snow and the sky that spread out above in a huge, daunting swath was pregnant with a roiling storm, dark and churning, and already wet flakes of snow as big as flower petals dropped in fast vertical paths to the bare farm fields where her children had once nurtured livestock.

Maceo painted, and she did as well, both of them quiet with rapture, the sounds of their brushes beating on the canvas like drums riding in syncopation overtop of the steady roar of the wood stove's fire. It was hot in the room, and her partner had donned his light garb again to work; a clean white T-shirt that clung to his frame, and paint-spattered cotton shorts. They'd painted for hours and now was the time she would have to stop and clean up, prepare for dinner. But that expectant sky told her John would be late, likely very late, because soon the sky would fill with snow, blotting out the fading dusk light and clogging the roads.

Hunger wormed at her but the call of the work was stronger. Still, they painted with fervor. As dusk came the world out the windows went white with a torrent of sideways snow moving across the farm fields like a freight train. Then the world went black with night but the slashing sleet out the window shone in the porch light. Her back curled forward in hunched tension, and her eyes narrowed—she'd lost herself in the work but

something was cracking and a way out was showing itself to her. The closer she came, the more she feared escape, even if it came with epiphany, because without the thrill of chase she feared this thrill would leave her forever, and the ghostly hand reaching out to grasp what it sought, closed to a weak claw, faded, fell...



* * *

Brush set down, she stared, felt herself panting as if with exhaustion. Her working hand ached and the two middle knuckles pinged with the high throbbing note of what she swore was arthritis. Hand pulled protectively between her breasts, the other hand working and kneading a thumb to soothe its partners, she examined what she'd created from nothing.

After completing perhaps two dozen landscapes over the last three years, working from photos, here was work with inspiration, something built from experience and communicated without reference. It sung with energy. The sky crackled with meaning, a ridge line took shape below, a farmhouse was obscured by snow. She was done.

What sung inside her had told its lyrics and here was something she was proud of, done and exhausted in a total of hours. But instead of lost excitement, it was renewed; she wanted to go again, like riding a roller coaster through its course, arriving at its covered depot and the waiting lines, her soul ran its finger around in a whirlybird signal to the operator: *Let's do it all again, captain!*

She stepped back and whispered, "Whoah."

Maceo noticed the change in her energy and set his brush down, too. He watched her first, then regarded her painting.

Self-consciousness worked at her again and now she heard her echo whispering a prideful whoah and how a talented young artist might perceive that in comparison with the work on the canvas. It made her shrug in submissive surrender, and now she scowled at her own landscape as if in scrutiny. With a timid tone she said to him, "I don't know—what do you think?"

Instead of telling her, he took her shoulders and turned her to face him; his expression was intense and serious and it startled her. His eyes held hers

with unexpected ferocity, and when she looked away toward the painting, he took her chin and turned her gaze back to him. He said, "Don't look at it, look at me. What do *I* think?—you want to know? Look at me, tell me how you *feel*..."

She faltered, said, "I don't know," and heard the weakness of a whine in her voice. She could tell by Maceo's eyes he was bothered by the sound. The grip his large hands had on her shoulders tightened.

"You do," he said, brow lowering, "tell me."

Nothing came to her except for one word. "Amazing," she whispered.

"Are you embarrassed?" he said, and the slightest of smiles touched his lips. Instant relief flooded her.

"I guess..."

"Tell me..."

"I feel *amazing*," she said with a growing confidence.

"You should," he said with firmness. Now he turned her again, and they both faced the canvas. "Look what you did. Look at this beauty..."

They both regarded it for a full and foreboding moment.

He said, "That's you, that's real. You did that here," he said and touched two fingers to her temple, "but also here," and his hand dropped to touch those two fingers between her breasts, over her heart. She was acutely aware of the pressure, kept her eyes on the painting but could instead picture that big hand with its tanned color, the long fingers and big knuckles, and the lines of the thick veins drawn on the backs. Her scalp tightened, her hair rose; her nipples rolled over painfully inside the tightness of her bra—but she didn't move from his touch nor guide his hand away for fear of embarrassing him or herself. *You're wearing a shirt and a bra, stop thinking so highly of yourself, he's just being nice.* And she was happy for his help, his instruction.

She said, "It's like I've been swimming with water wings... Do you know what those are?"

He made no sound, and she didn't look to him, kept her eyes on the painting she'd done. "I'm swimming on my own," she said.

The fingers left her chest, but his hand remained on her back, just below the nape of her neck. "It's beautiful, Janie," he said.

"Thank you," she said earnestly and hoped he understood she meant not just for the compliment but for his influence.

Tears swelled her eyes, and she moved her hands to her face and stepped away from her painting before she made a fool of herself. Her mouth worked around, opening so she could breathe—if she tried through her nose, she knew she would make a wet snuffle. “How about you?” she said and could hear a thickness in her voice she hoped he would miss.

“I paint some friends I miss,” he said.

The canvas on his easel was unfinished; two faces, two people, close together, a young man and a young woman with similar features. “Are they brother and sister?” she asked, letting loose with a single quiet snuffle and then clearing her throat.

“Yes, they are my cousins. My father’s brother, they live in the country.”

“You ever visit them?”

“When we were younger, yes. But not in a while. They come to see me in Rome.”

“They’re beautiful.”

“Thank you... Yes, they are.”

She examined his work now, hoping she could give him the same kind of support she felt from him. The two faces were close together in the center of the canvas, just above the middle line, close together; sparkling eyes, cheeks mashed together and she couldn’t believe how well he’d captured that, just a thin white line to show shine on the raised parts where their flesh pressed. It was unbelievable talent he had; he’d done it all from inside his head. The two faces were almost complete, the hair roughed in, beginning to show form and detail. Their hands were together, the young man with one on his hip, the other in his lap, the girl with both her hands in her lap. But it was just rough, almost blurry. Then around their faces, more emptiness. There was texture there, brush strokes that showed something would happen, but she didn’t know yet what it was. She sighed, said, “Your work is so beautiful. I wish I could paint like you.”

“You see things, you can paint them.”

“I see things...”

“Then you can paint them.”

“I just wish I could draw figures as well as you do.”

“You can, Janie. You can...”

She laughed. “No, I can’t. I showed you already, I showed you I can’t draw people...”

“You can, you just push it away.”

“Push what away?”

“I don’t know what it is. But it’s like... a block,” he said, and drew a sort of brick shape in the air.

“You think I’m walling myself off?”

“That’s it, yes... You putting up barrier.”

“I just can’t draw figures, Maceo.”

“You *can*—show me.”

“I already did,” she said. That first day they painted, she showed him her sketchbook. Landscapes were one thing, but her figure work was amateurish.

“Janie, come on. Don’t you believe me?”

“No,” she laughed and folded her arms.

Now he smiled. “You see, there is your barrier,” and those big hands came and touched her folded arms. Her sleeves were rolled up, and the warmth of his palm was felt across both her forearms. He opened her arms away, breaking her barriers as it were, but in effect he’d taken her shield away from her breasts. She felt a tightness there again and hoped she wasn’t showing evidence through her shirt.

“Come on,” he said, “come on and show me.” He took down the painting that was on his easel, set it against the worktable, went around behind and took another brand-new canvas out of a package. He brought it and set it on the easel’s ledge. Now he went through pastels and pencils and presented one to her. A charcoal stick. He said, “Come on and show me again.”

“I can’t, Maceo,” she said.

“Janie, come on. You trust me, yes? You just said you feel it—you feel *amazing*, no?”

“I did,” she said, looking over her shoulder at the work she’d done. She felt confident about that, and chasing it down was what had made her feel amazing.

Now he touched her chest again, right in that spot where she could practically still feel where he pressed his fingertips before. He said, “Do it from here. Don’t do with your eyes, don’t do it with your mind. Let your heartbeat push the blood to your arm, let your arm work from your feelings.”

“You make it sound so easy,” she said, “but *you* can draw.”

"*You* can draw, Janie... Come on," he said again, and now he went to the blank canvas, snatched up the pencil from the table, and she watched the way he loosely held it between thumb and finger, the pencil tip dancing across the canvas, and soon she could see the rough shape of a figure. He said, "There, the hard stuff is done..." He smiled.

"That's not the hard stuff."

"You think everything is hard."

"What am I supposed to draw?"

"Draw me, Janie," he said, "come on, here," he stood, looking for a good place where light would fall on him, then he posed for her, nothing extravagant, nothing that would make her laugh or make her roll her eyes. Just blankly standing in a calm state of repose. His face was somber. He said, "How's the light?"

"You look good," she said.

"Then put it down on the canvas."

She looked at the lines he'd made on the canvas showing the sense of where a figure would be; scale, how large the face would be and what it would take up on the blank space. She said, "How do I start?"

"Start with the eyes. That's all that matters."

"The eyes, huh?"

"Start with my eyes, Janie."

She drew a straight line about halfway down from the top of the shape of the head that Maceo had drawn. Then she worked a line down the center, put the pencil where they intersected, moved to the left and drew a rough almond shape, then she took her thumb to measure the distance between where the bridge of the nose would separate the second eye. She said, "Is it one eye width apart?—is that right?"

"Janie, don't worry about math. Don't worry about proportion, it's not the length of your thumb, it's in your heart. Let your hand go."

"Maceo, I told you. I just *can't*," and now that whine came back in her voice, and instead of being embarrassed by it this time, she felt emboldened. She had a reason to whine. This was ridiculous. She set the pencil down in the tray.

Maceo was on her instantly, and those warm hands wrapped each of her wrists now and he turned her to face him. He said, "Janie, you feel it now, you just had a victory with that painting, don't let it get away from you. Do it from your heart. It's there, I promise you, it's there."

“Nothing’s there, Maceo.”

He tugged on her forearms to get her attention. He said, “What do you have a problem with?”

“I can draw landscapes.”

“You can draw figures, too, Janie.”

“They’re too hard, they don’t look right...”

“You have shame, don’t you?”

“*That’s* why I can’t draw figures?” She frowned.

“You’re afraid to. You afraid you don’t see the human body the way others see it.”

“I see them just fine, Maceo.”

Now his eyes were steady on her and he said, “You saw mine the other night, how did you act?”

Exploration

Her mouth hung open; she couldn't believe he would throw that up in her face. She was mad all at once, wanted to yank her hands away from him and end this, but instead she defended herself. "You were *naked*."

"Exactly. And what's wrong with that?"

"Nothing's wrong with it, Maceo, I just wasn't expecting it."

"And how did you act?"

She stared at him for a long moment, searching for his meaning, and then decided to trust his line of questioning. He hadn't steered her wrong. "Embarrassed," she answered.

"You were. But why?"

"I told you: you were naked."

"There is your barrier. You have shame."

"You don't have any," she said.

It was a sarcastic quip, meant to make him laugh, but he shook his head as if he couldn't believe she would stoop to such rudimentary diversion. "I have nothing to be ashamed of. You're right. So put it down on the paper. Draw the figure," he said. "Shape it out, don't worry about the face and how far apart eyes are supposed to be," he let her hands go and stepped back, resumed his standing pose.

She wanted to roll her eyes, could feel herself slumping, and then could picture the way her daughter did that and how angry it used to make her. *Marissa, for crying out loud, you just pull and roll the teet downward, you're milking a cow not building a bridge.* Petulance was an aggravation, and now *she* was aggravating. He was a nice young man who was enormously talented, and he wanted to help her. She was being a 'Marissa,' standing in her pink rubber boots and crying because she didn't know how to milk a cow. *It was just so damn simple, Marissa, you just need to listen and then do it.*

She took up the pencil again, and this time she didn't worry about things you read in a book about the angle of the shoulders and how they related to the chest in line with the sternum. She just let her pencil move over the

page, and she could hear Maceo saying, “Yes, that’s it, go,” and now she was, moving her hand around; it wasn’t coming out right, but she squinted and narrowed her eyes, stuck with it. She moved the lead point around in squiggly shapes that looked amateurish still but she was seeking something again and just like she chased down that picture that came out of her mind about a barn in a storm and a bewildering sky, she pushed until she found the shape of the figure.

She stepped back, and he said, “Why are you stopping?

“That’s not terrible,” she said, looking at her work.

“It’s not terrible at all, Janie. You see it, you can see it coming?”

“It’s still so ugly. My pencil strokes, they don’t look like yours.” She set the pencil down again, stepped back to better look at her drawing. It wasn’t awful, but it was something any high school kid could do.

“You’re still trapped in your own mind.”

“Yeah, so what...? I’m trapped in my mind.”

“Don’t do that, you’re hurting yourself.”

“I’m not hurting anybody.”

“Janie, turn around.”

She did and this time she gave him a real good Marissa eye roll—and then interiorly she chastised herself. She stood straighter and looked at him.

He said, “Stop worrying about what it looks like on the paper. You getting caught there—put your hands on me.”

“No, come on, Maceo...”

“What? Touch me, feel me. That’s where I am, I’m real, I’m standing right here. See me, put your hands on me...”

“I can’t do that, Maceo.”

“More barriers, more shields.”

“Don’t try to piss me off. I don’t fall for that.”

“I’m not try to piss you off,” he said, reached forward and took her wrists again. “Here,” he said, and yanked her so she stepped forward. He planted both her palms on his broad chest. He said, “Janie, look at me. Feel me.”

She let her hands stay there, but she gave him a stern gaze. *What was she afraid of?* This *was* the barrier. She was getting mad at him because he was right. She was a grown woman twice his age, and he was teaching her something about herself. Strong Janie, Janie who could do everything, Janie

with her strong back and her lonely spirit... She didn't like to be taught. She liked to learn, but she didn't like to be taught.

She moved her hands around from the center of his chest up to his collar. She squeezed at those muscles at the base of his neck, moved her hands over his shoulders and stopped.

He said, "That's it, feel me. Understand how I work. Understand how the shoulder connects to the chest. Not with numbers, not with theory, but with your heart. With your mind *and* your eyes, and not measurement done from textbooks. Really feel me..."

"I *am* feeling you," she said. She moved her hands around again in the same pattern, starting in the center of his chest moving up his collar down to his shoulders. When she'd done it, she started over again.

"That's it, and down lower, too, feel it..."

"I can't do that..."

"You doing it. You doing good. Do it with your heart, stop letting whatever barrier in your mind is getting in the way..."

"There's too much to know," she said.

"You *already* know it. Look at your painting of the barn."

"I've drawn many barns."

"You've *seen* many barns, that is how you know..."

"Look at your figures, look at the way their hands go in their lap, that's so hard, all the clothes, the folds... I have to stick to landscapes." She brought her hands back.

Maceo looked at her, and their eyes connected for a long moment. He watched her with concern as if her words had troubled him. He folded his arms in front of him, paused, eyes still watching her intently. Then he pulled his shirt up and over his head tossed it to the floor. He stood there now with no shirt on, just his low-riding paint-splattered shorts. He said, "There, no clothes, no folds, no fabric. This is human, feel it."

He didn't make a move to grab her wrists and put her hands on him. Her heart was pounding, and her left eye twitched. She said, "What do you want me to do?"

"See me and then draw me."

She watched him again for a long quiet while, the hugeness of the moment growing even larger. She put out her right hand, her painting hand, rested it on his bare chest. He was warm to the touch, his skin was smooth. There was a sparse swash of hair below his collar that ran down. She

remembered him from Tuesday night when she'd been face-to-face with him naked. He was right, she *could* remember, see the familiarity of what she'd seen. She remembered his body. It had been a forbidden thing, and it had made her frightened. But why?

Now she put her left hand on his chest as well and moved them around in that same circuit, starting in the center of his chest and up to his collar and then feeling the firmness of his shoulders. She said nothing. Everything she'd said up to this point was throwing something up in his face, a diversionary tactic. He was right about the shields. She didn't like to be taught, she didn't like to be told what to do. She liked to learn...

So she learned, she touched him for real. She let her fingertips explore, went around in circles again, studied the hard masculine shape of his chest. Her thumbs ran circles around the hard brown quarters of his nipples. The ones she'd admired when she sat on the edge of the bed and watched him while he slept. She was *really* feeling him, and she'd wanted to. Now she was doing it and she was learning. She wasn't being taught, she was learning. And she moved her hands lower, because she wanted to know.



* * *

Her hands worked over the ridges of his ribs, the serratus, according to textbooks, though she wasn't supposed to concern herself with the namesakes used in lectures or in theory, and she closed her eyes and felt the warm dips and hard edges.

"Open your eyes," he whispered, "feel how the light gives form to shape... and see it, too..."

She bit her lip, rotated her hands, fingers to the side, and slipped down his hard narrow waist and watching the thin bunched lines her hands pushed his young tight skin into. Both hands opened and out stretched like stars she felt his stomach now, the curls of his black hair drawing lines around his navel springing against her thumbs. She swooped up and back down again, low, then wide, her fingers resting on the rise of his hipbones.

"You understand?" he whispered.

"Yeah," she answered just as softly.

Maceo touched her now, tracing the backs of his fingers up the cotton of her shoulders, then down her chest barely touching her. She leaned forward, swooning, gripping the hardwood with her bare toes before she would fall. His hands took the hem of her T-shirt and lifted it—she raised her arms and he tossed it aside. The silk of her new haircut fell around her bare shoulders.

Now she stood before her handsome houseguest in just jeans and a bra, and he was shirtless, her mouth hung open and his eyes burned with intent.

“Are you going... to paint me?” she whispered.

“Would you sit for me?”

“I want to.”

But her hands returned to his beautiful body, pale wintry upstate hands moving over his supple Mediterranean flesh, feeling the young hard muscle below. His arms circled behind her and her face came so close to touching his chest he must feel her breath against his skin. Those long fingers of his worked the clasp of her bra and she closed her eyes. *Don't close them, Janie, open your eyes and see the light, see how it gives form to shape...*

He stepped back, and she held the cups of her bra in place and looked in his eyes, watched his face as she let the fabric fall and showed him her bare breasts. Her nipples ached, and the warm air of the room prickled against them. Her breaths came shaky from her open mouth.

“The light loves your body, Janie,” he said, eyes working over her admiringly, “it loves to show me your beauty...”

“Oh, God,” she sighed with a shaky voice.

With confidence, he stepped closer again, hands coming to her waist and working at the top button of her jeans. His strong warm hands touched her bared stomach, and it lit up like a field of butterflies aroused by sunlight; she tilted her chin up and looked in his eyes again. He unzipped her old faded Levi's and her breath chugged in whispers as she let him push them down her hips as though he had authority; like she allowed a doctor to examine her, so would she allow this incredible artist to put his talented eyes on her.

Eyes still on his, she took the waistband and pushed her jeans down to her knees, stepped her legs out of them, stood before him in only her panties. And without having to ask her, she was moving again, pushing the panties down and stepping out of them as well, her hands coming together between her legs to hide her ample tangle of pubic hair. She watched his eyes as they moved over her bared body, watched his hands guide her arms

apart and uncover for him that tangled womanly part of her. She grew faint as his eyes stroked over her naked body and her mind turned to static and floated high and light where there was little oxygen.

“So beautiful,” he said. Instead of reaching for a paintbrush, he unbuttoned his own shorts.



* * *

Frozen in place, she stood and watched those good-looking hands work the button out and then draw down his zipper. What was behind his fly had swelled and humped out the cotton where it hadn't before. She could see the shape of his large penis pressing against the fabric. Unbuttoned and unzipped, he only had to let his hold on the shorts go and they fell to the floor around his ankles. He wore no underwear.

The big thing that dangled between his legs was longer and fuller than she'd seen in her son's bedroom doorway. It bobbed side to side in stiff wags; one low hanging testicle rose higher while she watched. The intent was not to draw her. She tilted her face up and her eyes were slow to follow, still engaged by the size and arousal of his manhood.

When she met his gaze, he said, “Study me, Janie, look at me and touch me, and I will study you...” He stepped closer and she flinched at the weight of his hands on her shoulders. She rested her trembling palms on the hardness of his stomach again, let her eyes slowly travel from his, down his young and incredible body, down between his legs. A vein had swelled along the top side of his penis looking as thick as a pencil, it began inside his body, traveled the center of the shaft until it veered sharply sideways midway down; the bobbing of his huge organ grew pronounced, an upright jerking lifting it outward with each beat of his heart, the thing growing even longer, even thicker, lightly tapping against her thigh and stomach, rustling her full, womanly bush. Her hands fell lower until her thumb disappeared in the dense black bramble above the base of his organ. Her mouth was open, but she didn't breathe, her heart hammered and her vision paled.

His hands moved like silk over her skin until they cupped her breasts and he hefted them, cuddled them, studied them. She moved her painting hand down the inside of his thigh and slowly closed her fingers around his

hanging manhood. It was warm and gummy, surprisingly soft and pliable despite its size. Life pulsed through it and it continued to grow in her grip. She studied it in her hand, saw the pale stripe of her thumb across its dark width; she squeezed it gently, milked it downward just as she'd encouraged Marissa to milk the cows' teats.

Now Maceo stooped over her, hands still caressing her breasts, eyes gathering her gaze, lips parting to take her kiss.

"Oh, God, no," she sighed a desperate sound and let his penis go and stepped back from him.

He was striking, his eyes burning on her as snow beyond the window slashed sideways behind him; firelight from the wood stove flickered on the glistening edges of his twenty-year-old body; his penis continued to grow, a truly gargantuan arm extending out now to greet her, level with the floor, eager for her touch, eager to feel her insides. "Oh, Maceo, no," she said, squatted and gathered her things up and collected them against her front, trying to cover her nakedness. This wasn't art, this wasn't painting...

She backed away, turned, trotted then stopped, knowing he would watch her bare ass, and she worried it jiggled. At the archway to the main house she turned and walked backward. Maceo followed.

"Don't leave me, Janie," he said.

"Maceo, what are you doing?—what are *we* doing?"

She walked backwards faster, but he gained on her, that long appendage between his legs bobbing, swaying, bouncing with his urgent steps.

"Don't touch me," she warned him, clothes clenched tightly against herself.

That stopped him and he stayed one pace away. He held a hand out, that big beautiful man's hand, palm up, looking to take hers and hold it. "Janie, stay with me, talk with me."

"I can't, Maceo," she cried, darted a look over her shoulder, saw the stairs to the second floor but knew if she went up them he would follow close behind, watching her bare bottom close up. The pantry door was open next to her, and she slipped in and closed it behind her.

"Janie, don't—"

"No, Maceo," she said, her mouth close to the door. His body leaned against it and she could hear his hand sliding the surface on the other side.

"Please, let me in, Janie," he said, his deep voice came from the hall.

“No, Maceo, no,” she said and dropped her things on the floor after she’d found her panties in the bundle. She flicked the light switch on and the fluorescents flickered and then came on with their insect buzz. Panties wound around, she put her legs through the holes and pulled them up.

“Please, Janie, we don’t have to do anything, I just want to be with you, I want to know you’re okay...”

“I’m fine,” she said, and ran her hair back from her face with both hands, clamped them on either side of her neck, leaned against the corner of a shelf and slid her bare back down feeling the metal snag and scratch at her skin until she sat on the floor in the garish light.

A dreadful ache had begun in her middle, two hard knots swelling under her skin, deep in her core; throbbing points just above her hip bones. The flat of her hand pressed against the discomfort, against her stomach. The pressure brought a tickle of warm wet expulsion from the nest of wrinkled membranes between her legs. She groaned, tucked a thumb down the front of her panties and pulled them away. A dewy shine had been painted on the inside and drops sparkled in her pubic hair. Her hand slipped inside her panties and cupped her sex.

“Janie, come out, please...”

“I can’t, Maceo.”

“I’m coming in.”

Instead of saying no, she groaned and closed her eyes. The door opened, and he came in, walking on his knees, his prodigious erection wagging. She closed her eyes again. “We can’t, Maceo.”

She listened as he shuffled along, heard the clinking of glass jars of pickled vegetables from her garden this summer as he sat down across from her. The room was silent but for the fluorescent’s buzz. When she opened her eyes, she found him watching her. Even in the harsh light the boy was gorgeous; he sat like her, long hair hanging down on one side, watching her with smoldering eyes. His jaw flexed, his brow soft with compassion; he imitated her, slumped against the shelf with his legs crossed. She crossed an arm over her breasts and looked away; felt the aroused nubs of her nipples against the inside of her forearm.

Still he said nothing, and she struggled to think of something to part the silence; but was also comfortable in it, somehow felt better with him on *this* side of the door.

She scoffed now, a chuckle. She looked back. “You’re crazy,” she whispered. He smiled and cocked his head. She bit her lip and laughed again until her laugh became a groan. He laughed with her and the hand he rested on his thigh slid upward and held his erection.

She studied his hand on it; a truly masculine and beautiful sight—something she had never seen in her life. That hand she’d admired for its talent and beauty gripped on a totem of ultimate masculinity, a tremendous erection, a symbol of his manhood, engorged and swollen with the paths of thick veins tracing over; his object of sexuality, his huge implement of pleasure and reproduction. He began to stroke it.

She groaned and chuckled again, watching.

His eyes were on her, moving over her body while he pleased himself a few feet away. Her hand was still inside her panties covering her slick sex. While she watched, her own fingers began to stroke, finding her opening as slippery as oil; her lubrication still seeped from her.

Maceo shifted, opened his legs wider, and she followed suit. Now they were angled in line toward each other, legs open and feet on the floor. His hand pumped up and down in slow strokes and she watched the large head of his cock, her own hand dancing under the thin cotton of her underwear bottoms, stroking and teasing at her opening.

Both of them watched the other pleasuring themselves for minutes until their heavy breaths came loud and quick and drowned out the buzz of the lights. The end of Maceo’s cock shone with wet and she could see clear excitement seeping from the slit in the end of his erection that looked big enough she could clamp a dime in its crease. She moaned and cried and gasped at that dirty thought, and her knees began to bow in and out as she masturbated for Maceo.

He slid his foot outward, purposely, with his eyes on hers until their ankles touched. At the feel of his body against hers she cried out again, moved her other foot until she could touch her other ankle against his.

“Oh, God,” she moaned out in a long dry sound and clamped both hands over her throbbing sex, one inside her panties, the other over top, squeezing on herself, trying to choke away its hungry need.

Maceo slowed his stroking, watching what she would do, tilting his chin up and resting the back of his head against a shelf. The light came down and cast shadows on his strong cheekbones.

She sat up, got on her knees, then changed her mind and sat on her heels. Changed her mind again and rose, crossed to his side, walking on her knee points. He let his cock go, and it rested against his stomach, long enough the crown of it touched his sternum. She kneeled between his open legs with her hands on her thighs, looking away from his arousal and meeting his gaze. He held his hand out again in that familiar way and she gave him hers. Her hand was dwarfed in his grip. She scooted her knees closer, touched his chest with her free hand. His cock flexed, and she saw it pulse lubrication over the hard edges of his torso. Her grip circled it. Even just under the head, her finger and thumb could barely meet. His hot skin was slippery with his excitement as she began to stroke him. The size of his erection made her movement clumsy and unsure; she'd never held anything like it.

His hand rested on her hip and she gasped with surprise. It was welcome though, and that deep toothache in her womanhood abated, thinking it might finally get some relief.

Steep Hills

Her breath trembled, her hand on his erection stilled—every bit of her narrowed to a fine focus on the feel of his fingers as they caressed her skin, her intimate skin, just above her panty line. And as though her own psyche commanded it, his fingertips turned downward and slid underneath. Her breath now came in soft but erratic trembling whispers as the tips of his fingers combed through her pubic hair, and her womanhood tingled with anticipatory static, desperate to be touched. Two of those big handsome fingers she'd admired slipped over her slit and she turned her chin down, found Maceo studying her face.

One hand on his manhood, her other stroked his neck and cheek as he began to slip his fingers back and forth. Her mouth stayed hung open, he bit gently on his lower lip; the two tips eased so gently inside her.

Slowly, his face went blurry and she let out an embarrassing moan. Deeper his fingers entered her, and she went hazy bright, and her eyes closed. She eased herself forward and rested her bare chest against his. The hard knob of his cock head pressed between her hanging breasts, its slippery tip sliding along her skin. A long whispering exhale breathed from her as she surrendered to his touch.

She eased higher, hiding her face in his neck and collar as he stroked his fingers in and out of her. Hips tilted forward, she turned her bottom up so he could penetrate her deeper. When he did, she fell against him fully and he cradled her as though she were fainting, and while she never lost consciousness the fluttering of it was real; her heart raced, her pulse along with it, the veins in her neck throbbed like downed wires and her *core* ached for him, ached to feel the hardness inside her that merely pressed against her stomach right now.

They rolled to the side, Maceo still supporting her, his hand cupped behind her head. Then he was over top of her and she was on her back, the cold of the pantry floor chilling her skin, but not extinguishing the heat that was cooking her insides. Maceo's beautiful face was over hers, his thick hair in a tangled comber. Around him, extending upward and distant in a

single point perspective right out of one of her art instruction books: the familiar angles of her stocked pantry shelves and the wet of gloss ivory she painted the ceiling when the kids were little.

Now his free hand was tugging on her panties and she rolled side-to-side as he worked them down.

“No,” she whispered but watched her hands smooth the angles of his face as her thumbs caressed under his dark eyes that held her gaze and didn’t want to let go. Her knees went wide and Maceo got between them, his long thick manhood tapping over her tummy.

“Tell me you want me,” he said, the fronts of his thighs patting against the backs of hers as he got himself in position to penetrate.

“I want you so bad, Maceo, I want you,” she sighed, thumbs feeling that beautiful face. The tip of his cock moved through her bush as he arched his back and dragged his erection over her skin. “But I can’t, I can’t...” she cried.

Then his hand was on her thigh, the inside, just above her knee, slipping in a warm sweep higher, going to her apex, cupping her sex—she let out a low howl and closed her eyes as he slid what felt like three of those artist’s fingers deep inside her, fully, feeling as large as a penis. She cried with regret and pleasure and curved her hands over the hard shapes of his shoulders.

She watched his eyes through narrowed blurry slits as he fucked her hard with his fingers. She squeezed her thighs against his waist, dug her nails into his flesh; the sound between her legs grew slushy and slick but she was far too gone to be shy, instead now reaching between them and gripping his huge, hard cock. Her fist closed around that fat, full head as big as a plum and the cushion of her thumb caressed the slit—when she found it slick and dripping she cried out again, knowing his body was proving to her how eager this gorgeous twenty-year-old man was to make love with her. The whole while he thrust long fingers through her insides, she met his gaze and began stroking him hard and fast.

“Yeah, do it,” she grunted.

He bit that lower plump lip again and met the pace of her stroke with the thrust of his fingers. They mated their syncopation staring into each other’s eyes. The feel of his hardness in her hand, the effect of his gaze—pinning her to the floor with his eyes—built unsustainable pleasure in her inner valves and pipelines and a warbling sound filled the room, but her

ears had popped with pressure and it didn't occur to her right away that it was *her* making the noise, that uncontrollable pleasure was producing cries of ecstasy.

Her hand stilled and squeezed on him hard, her grip squishing his plump round end with slick strength and now her butt curled and raised off the floor, the small of her back pressed the cold tile and her vision narrowed to a dim star point on Maceo's face.

A rumbling that had threatened her from a distance, roaring in the distance, had warned her, came after her like a freight train now, shaking and rattling her tracks hard enough to loosen her joints, her teeth clamped down hard and she nipped the tip of her tongue. Breath snorted and scored her nostrils and she seized under Maceo, her body twisting and torquing, her hand tightened like a clamp on his cock, and she twisted her body, writhed on her pantry floor as pleasure expanded against all her seams looking to blow her to shreds. She had to cry out before she burst. Both her hands gripped his neck now, and she dragged her nails on his skin as she humped against his digital penetration—no, *fucked* against it—she fucked against him and came hard and huge and explosive in a dazzling phosphorescent orgasm that had her eyes shut so tight stars sparkled behind in the mental black like constellations.

The orgasm went through her like a thunderclap and it left her hairline pounding like someone knocked her forehead with a rubber mallet—but wet ecstasy still flooded her system and she made high moaning sounds, sucking her lips. She stopped his hand by grabbing his wrist.

Vision just a wet warbling slit, she watched him, trembling, panting, crying. Tears flooded her eyes and her hand fumbled around until it gripped his hard club and closed over the thick end. She cried and stroked, small hand jacking him up and down. He humped his hips, pushing his thing to thrust through her quick jerking movements—and it brought his breath faster and faster, and though she cried she encouraged him: “That’s it, yeah, okay?”

He grunted and groaned and the muscles on his arms flexed, raising up against the skin like cables, his torso tightened and twisted—he held his breath then made a low restrained roar in his throat. He ejaculated in thick jags that spurted her chest, the second one touching her chin; she slowed her stroke, turned it to squeezes and caresses while semen still pulsed from him and breath snorted. He hid his face against his shoulder.

“Look at me,” she whispered, “don’t look away.” Her voice was thick with sadness.

Maceo didn’t only look at her, he held her gaze and lowered his lips to kiss her. Hers parted in heart-racing anticipation and they kissed. His lips were as soft and damp as she imagined, cool and strong, and he pulled gently on her mouth. Her hand stroked down his slick manhood and cradled his hanging testicles. They were large, too, and settled in the cup of her palm with gentle weight. She closed her hand on them while they continued to kiss.

It was brief, contracted—two heartbeats before she whispered, “Let me up.”

Maceo did, backing off her and staying on his knees. While she sat up, she looked down. Thick wandering tracks of his semen ran over her breasts and the folds of her stomach in shining rivulets. Her right hand was streamed with his pearly expulsion. She used the back of both wrists to squish tears out of her eyes. Maceo’s large hand caressed her cheek and gripped her neck; her head tilted to press it against her shoulder. He slumped to sit next to her.

He asked, “Are you crying?”

“No,” she lied and looked away but still pinched his hand against her neck.

“I don’t want you to cry.”

“I’m not,” she said.

He traced her earlobe with his thumb. “Can I kiss you again?” he asked.

She chuckled, looked in his young eyes that had little wisdom, but lots of care and compassion and hope. “No,” she said. She looked down his body, in his lap. He was so beautiful; his muscle, his definition, the young, supple, tanned skin, that masculine grace; his incredible manhood resting over his ankle. “I have to get up. I have to get out of here before I scream.”

“Stay with me,” he whispered, pulling her closer by her neck. Her hands on his chest stopped him.

“No, Maceo,” she said.

His hand caressed her hair, cupped the back of her head and he tried to get her to look at him. She wouldn’t. She rose, left him sitting, opened the pantry door.

Beyond the kitchen window, the dashing snow and the tangle of trees that framed the yard where the kids used to have their trampoline pulsed in

steady throbbing orange; the unexpected light traced all the polished and raised surfaces of her clean but darkened kitchen.

Running lights. Orange. The ones on the top of the F250. John was home...



* * *

Gear lever down to reverse again, he backed the F250 into the driveway's turnaround, lurched forward pushing another shovelful of snow toward the tree line. Visibility was low, the snow was really coming down—not just down, but *sideways*.

Evan and Marissa's Yukon was parked up next to Janie's pickup. He put the truck in reverse and rolled back again, truck beeping and dragging its shovel. He jammed on the lever to lift the blade, looking up at the vehicles. They had a young, strong kid staying with them, Janie would send him out with a shovel to clean around the cars and the walkways. He had about a dozen more driveways to do and then check up to make sure the big trucks were on the roads and doing okay before he would be home.

He put the truck in park, shook his head. It would be easier for him to do it, just take him a few minutes.

"Hold on, Sheba," he said, and stepped out of the warmth of the cab into the blistering side-slashing cold. He hauled off the metal blade shovel from the back of his truck, pulled up the hood on his work coat and headed up the garden path. He shoveled it left and right, working up to the wraparound porch, then down again, getting around the cars. It would have to be done again, but maybe Janie would remember and send Maceo out.

He paused now at the mouth of the path that lead up to the homestead, one arm over the handle of the shovel. The windows were dark.

Why were they dark?

He smiled now, thinking of his wife in the addition with Maceo, back where the light wouldn't be seen. The young guest had sparked something in her and he hoped they were both painting their butts off while he worked. But standing at the mouth of the walk, smiling into the snow that made his lashes flutter and collected in his beard, an ominous sort of dread droned through him like a far off klaxon's call. While his smile faltered a moment,

it returned. His eyes went over the blank windows, his hand came up to stroke snow from his beard. The darkness came with a foreboding, a warning, and it slithered and curled in his belly like an anfractuous coil.

But battling against that devious internal worm came flashing images of the love of his life happy, exuberant even, dabbing paint on a canvas while a young man from Italy provoked the finest feelings in her she'd felt for the longest time. He heard imaginary music they listened to while they painted; Bittersweet Symphony and the summer of '97, the best free summer of his life. There'd been better ones, ones when he was a dad, but when he was a young man in love, '97 was the biggie. The year they both fell deeper in love with each other and were tested, put on the rack and stretched and pulled. It wasn't easy, especially for Janie, pregnant at seventeen—but despite the terror of the unknown they'd come through it because they were in love, and now in retrospect, looking back after a lifetime with her where they raised that baby then had another, bought a homestead, and ran a successful business, well, it was a profoundly sweet thought to think of his beloved woman like the last time she'd spent free and young.

He returned to the truck, threw the shovel in the back, and grabbed his thermos—he'd get a fill up with some coffee before he got back on the road. Thermos in hand, he stood in the 'V' of the truck's open door, looking back at the house, snow pelting his face and the heat from the truck washing his neck under his beard. Sheba yawned. On the radio, tuned to the Wolf, they came out of a commercial into a storm update, then Oasis's 'D'You Know What I Mean?' He chuckled. Not Verve but close enough to make his smile broaden. *Leave them be, John.*

"Alright, Sheebs, let's plow some snow," he said, shoving himself into his seat and plopping his thermos into the holder. He'd stop at the Dunkin' on his way out toward Cheektowaga.

Closed in the cab, drumming along on the steering wheel, he flicked the toggle for the salter, pulled forward and backed up toward the parked vehicles, and then headed down the steep hill tossing salt to keep his driveway safe.



* * *

The cotton clung to her skin with the wet of Maceo's semen. She'd dressed in a hurry, frantic, but at least the adrenaline chased the tears away. Maceo stepped into the kitchen now, dressed again in shorts and T-shirt—he'd returned naked to the studio to put his clothes back on while she'd gone to the kitchen. Now she stood at the dining room window watching the red cast from John's tail lights fade from the snow on the tree boughs.

"He's gone?" Maceo asked.

Arms folded, looking back at the window as her husband headed back on the road for a long overnight, she said, "He is."

"Close," Maceo said, then stood watching her and not saying anymore.

She turned and looked at him, his strong, tall body, his handsome face, unsure. She said nothing either, just stared knowing he wouldn't see any more than her black silhouette against the bright of the snow out the window.

After a long moment, Maceo said, "Are you mad at me?"

"No."

More staring, more quiet, Maceo shifted his weight to the other foot, rested a hand on the countertop. "What happens now?" he asked.

Tears swelled again, but she kept quiet, mouth working around and sucking on her teeth. "I'm going to bed," she said.

"It's early, Janie," he said, but she was moving, going around the dining room table to the bottom of the stairs. Maceo went through the kitchen clockwise and around the stone chimney to intercept her.

"It's *early*, Janie," he said again and reached for her.

She squeezed herself against the newel post and kept away from his reach. "Do what you want—I'm going to bed," she said in a hoarse whisper.

"Janie..."

She was gone, hustling quietly up the stairs with her arms folded, the steps creaking and groaning. Maceo stayed on the first floor and she closed herself in the master bedroom. She sat on the bed for a long time, head cocked and eyes staring at the clothes hanging on hooks on the wall by the bathroom door. Her mind mostly stayed blank but sometimes lurid images would flash at her and sometimes chilling fear would creep up her back as she considered the distinct possibility Maceo would mount the stairs, open her bedroom door and enter. What would she do? Would she fight him? The guns were in lockers in the storage space.

It wasn't even like that, Janie. He didn't do a thing you didn't want. So, what?—would she lay back and have extramarital sex in the bed she shared with her loving husband? One who also loved her deeply in return?

More than half an hour passed before she heard any sound in the house—the weight of a man coming up the stairs. She went quiet and listened, holding her breath and staring wide but seeing nothing. She heard the familiar sound of Evan's door opening and then closing. She exhaled with what she would convince herself was relief.

Numb and cottony, she rubbed her thighs, heard no more, so rose and went into the bathroom. She got undressed, her shirt had crusted to her stomach. She balled the clothing and left it by the scale on the bathroom floor and ran a hot shower. Once it was steaming, she stepped in and began an arduous process of sudsing and scrubbing away the evidence of another man on her skin. The soap went slippery over the trails of Maceo's semen. She scrubbed until her skin squeaked, doing it in the dark, lights off in the bathroom and the bedroom. *But the doors were unlocked.* That bathroom door could open any second and Maceo would enter, come and join her in the shower...

Her hands found her sex slick still. She explored with her fingers, soaping as she went. She nibbled on the inside of her cheek thinking of the orgasm. It had been a while. Months ago she masturbated in here with the shower wand...

She squeaked the taps off and dried herself with a thick terry towel, blow dried her hair and then dressed in her pajamas. She bundled the stained clothing by the door to the sewing room and sat on the bed listening for any sound from her son's bedroom.

Mantle

The snow stopped at about three-twenty in the morning but he didn't return to High Countertop until 6 A.M. The lights were all off except for two porch lights, one on the north as he rose up the hill and the other on the south over the front door. Snow had built up around the cars and the walkway again but he'd shovel it away when he woke and give the driveway another scraping—he didn't want to disturb anyone's sleep.

He and Sheba walked the path in the frigid dark. The sky was dawning behind him, changing from black to gunmetal. He went around past the front door to the west side and came in through the mudroom, doffing his coat and boots. The top of the dryer was still warm like Janie had been doing laundry late at night. Sheba trotted to the kitchen looking for a drink of water. Though he was asleep on his feet, his eyes feeling swollen and puffy, he turned left before the pantry and entered the addition.

A dull bed of coals glowed in the wood stove and he added a log. There was a table lamp behind the couch on Janie's side and he clicked it on. Two paintings rested on the easels. Janie's struck him. It was the landscape she'd had sitting here for a few days, and now it looked like it was done. It wasn't like anything she'd painted before and yet he knew it was hers. Maceo's was fine work, too, very polished and accomplished, two young people sitting together.

Just like the belly of that wood stove when he'd come in here, a bed of fiery coals picked up heat and light in his own stomach as a jealous breeze wafted over their hungry surfaces. His wife had a new companion. A young and handsome one. Talented in the way she appreciated. They had a lot of time together. They'd spent the evening painting, the two of them alone. Heat rose and prickled on the back of his neck. He rubbed it away, still staring at his wife's painting.

A jingling behind him had him turning; Sheba standing and licking her sated, dripping chops and waiting for him to go up to bed with a restrained impatience.

"I'm coming, Sheeba," he said.

In the kitchen, he stopped again. His neck burned and his stomach tightened. Something was off, something not right, like a metallic taste where there should be none or an electric crackle in the air. He looked around the kitchen, moved to the sink. No dishes in the rack, nothing cleaned by hand. He opened the dishwasher. Only a quarter full, still had breakfast dishes and OJ glasses. *They didn't eat dinner?* There was something unnerving about that. Like they'd done other things instead. Painting, though. That was obvious. They worked through dinner. But now he could picture them out eating at a restaurant instead. Staying up late and painting and then rushing out to get something to eat together to celebrate. He could see them the way he'd found them earlier this week, a table for two and sharing a whole bottle of wine. That made him check the cupboard, but it looked like they hadn't partaken.

Sheba was watching him from the bottom of the stairs, back feet on the ground, fronts up on the second step.

"Yes, yes," he whispered to her and headed up the stairs while she raced ahead.

At the top of the stairs, the dread returned again, and he paused at Evan's door. It was ajar. There was no sound from within; no snoring or breathing. Sheba waited at the master bedroom, and he resisted the urge to push Evan's door open and check on Maceo.

"Don't you scratch at that door, Sheeba, I'm coming," he said and moved on, letting Sheba in the bedroom ahead of him.

Janie was in their bed and sleeping and Sheba joined her, jumping up at the foot and going around in five circles before curling in a crescent and tucking her face into her hindquarters. Janie didn't stir at all.

He went in the can and brushed his teeth, looked in his bleary bloodshot eyes, scratched his nails through his thick beard and threw his clothes in the laundry hamper, went to bed in his boxers and T-shirt, slipping under the covers next to Janie. She smelled so clean—soap and shampoo and laundry detergent, and he regretted climbing in wearing the same skivvies he'd put on over twenty-four hours ago.

He groaned, got out of bed and went through his drawers quietly and found sweatpants, put those on and got back into bed shirtless. Janie stirred now, making a soft moan and scooting closer to him, he put out an arm and she curled her fresh smelling body against his. The bare skin of her forearm rustled through his chest hair and it stirred him between his legs quickly and

unexpectedly. The softness of her skin, her clean smell—but let's face it, that new haircut, too. Not just how it accentuated her face but the very fact she had done it. It coincided with Maceo's arrival and he wasn't blind. This would only be admitted to himself: they had a farm-stay about six years ago, a smart, quick-witted black girl from Uganda, confident and eighteen-years-old, and she had a light in her eyes that put a spark in him. There was not a single thing between him and that girl, nor did he want there to be (nor did she!), but she had him smiling and doing sit-ups, feeling young and watching what he ate. No one called him on it, *he caught himself*, cursing, *Don't be so obvious, John, you'll look foolish!* And that's what Janie was doing, only she hadn't realized how obvious she was yet. She might be embarrassed once Maceo returned to Italy and he wouldn't call her on it until then. He remembered that spark and how good it made him feel. It was benign and sweet in its own way—reminding him what it was like when he was eighteen. So he'd let Janie have her thrill. *Plus, look at this, Johnny-boy...* With his wife in one arm, curled against his big hairy chest like a Conan the Barbarian poster he could see the hump of a bona fide erection, a good one, a real throbbler under the blankets. He kissed the top of Janie's head and squeezed her a little snuggler and she made a sweet cooing sound and nuzzled her forehead into his beard.

With his wife in his arm he regarded down the foot of the bed past the humps of his feet under the blanket and Sheeb's fuzzy back. There, leaning on the wall and sitting on the fireplace mantle was a painting of Janie. Beautiful Janie with a look in her eyes that lightened his heart and made him ache for when they were young. It was painted by a young, tall, handsome man sleeping just across the hall, one who his wife might have the slightest crush on.

But more, and this is where an ache began, he wondered how a young man from so far away, who'd known his wife for not even a week, could capture her so perfectly. How could he know her so well, so apparently deeply? What Maceo had brought to life in that pastel drawing was astounding. And as he lay in bed with the woman he'd loved for so long laying against him sweetly breathing, he looked up at the way another man saw his wife's beauty, had captured it so raw and pure. His cock throbbed under the bedding and he lay a hand over its belly and squeezed, kissed his wife's silky blonde head and tried to close his eyes.

Afterword

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